

create



set the style & structure

You've thoughtfully planned your communication. Now, it's time to create the materials that will support you. This section focuses on content that will be organized into a slide deck, which I find is the most common form of business communication for meetings and presentations. For those communicating in different ways, many of the following strategies will be transferable to other scenarios; I encourage you to apply your thoughtful judgment.

I'm also working under the assumption that the content will be *presented*. You or someone else will talk through the materials you create. This could be in person or in a virtual setting, and we'll cover strategies to use in each of these situations. In either case, there is an important idea to keep in mind when developing the deck: **your slides are not what will do the communicating—you are.**

This runs counter to how we typically operate, aiming instead to make slides that stand on their own. That's a reasonable goal for material that we will disseminate. However, when creating content to present live, your slides are there to support you, not the other way around! Because of this, there are different design considerations for material that you will present. Think of your slides as a useful assistant. They can provide visual illustrations of concepts, aid you in explaining details, remind you of the next topic, or reinforce the

ideas that you raise. But *you* are the one who will do most of the communicating. Your slides should augment you as the presenter.

When it comes to our slide decks, they may contain a combination of words, graphs, and images. These are the main types of content that we'll explore in this section (Chapters 6, 7, and 8, respectively). Before we do that, in this chapter we'll get super practical and set the foundational style and structure.

Set the style and structure first

It's time to open your presentation software. However, you *aren't* going to make slides quite yet. First, spend time actively setting the style and structure of your communication. While this might seem like a superfluous step, it is this action that will set the content you generate apart in positive ways and ensure the slides you create support the story you have planned.

When it comes to style, I'm referring to slide design, primarily: color, font, and layout. In the same way that we think about what experience we want to create for our audience in the context of story, keep this in mind when making stylistic decisions as well. Perhaps there is existing branding to incorporate, or you might want to start from scratch. We'll discuss each of these situations and how, in either event, your design choices should be congruent with the subject matter and desired tone of your presentation.

Setting the structure, or framework, of the presentation allows us to bring the output from our low-tech planning process into our tools. This breaks the development of our materials into manageable chunks so we can optimize our content creation time. When working in a team, doing this step up front helps get everyone on the same page and imparts an understanding of how individual pieces will be woven into the overall presentation. This lends visible harmony to the communication.

In this chapter, I'll share the pragmatic, three-step approach that I use and teach for setting the design and framework for your presentation:

1. Determine the style;
2. Make the slide master; and
3. Set the structure.

Let's begin with step one.

Determine the style

Color, font, and layout: these design aspects come together to create the overall look and feel of your materials. In some cases, these decisions have already been made for you. In other instances, you'll make your own choices. There are pros and cons to each of these scenarios.

Brand-driven style

Your company or organization may have already spent time establishing and defining their brand. This likely translates into designated colors and specific fonts that are suggested or required. It's possible a style guide exists that outlines these and other particulars, like proper use of your company logo. There might even be a pre-designed template for your presentation software with set colors, fonts, and layouts.

If this exists, use it.

While some balk at the idea of using branded templates due to the perceived constraints they impose, I suggest reframing. Using something that already exists is an easier starting point (particularly if you aren't a designer). This will make your process more efficient because there are far fewer decisions to consider. Standard templates also lend professionalism and consistency.

Conference slide templates

Large-scale conferences often provide speakers with presentation templates. In spite of this, when I prepare slides for a keynote address, I typically *don't* follow my own advice to use the provided template. This is because first and foremost I want to represent myself, my company, and my topic when I am speaking and not the conference. I understand organizers' desire to bring consistency to the various sessions and promote their brand. To meet my goals while also satisfying those of the organizers, I'll begin and end with the provided title and closing slides. Then I design my own slide template for my presentation (including my own title slide to transition into my content), in some cases tying in colors or fonts from the conference version so they feel cohesive. To see this in action, check out my 2019 Tableau Conference presentation, *low-tech super powers for data storytelling* (storytellingwithyou.com/superpowers).

The exception would be if the standard template really is awful. When people complain about presentation templates, the top gripes voiced have to do with color and visual distractions. Personally, I don't buy the our-brand-colors-are-horrible argument. This is perhaps true if you use multiple colors together, but thoughtful integration of black and gray to augment a single brand color will almost always alleviate this issue and is generally accepted, even given a required color palette. I'll show examples of this in forthcoming chapters.

Harder to overcome is when the slide template is already visually busy before you've added any content to it. This could be due to a vibrant background color or pattern, added embellishments, or a prominent logo. If you have to use something with a challenge like this, it means you have to be even more careful about what you add to the slide and generally put fewer elements than you would otherwise. You'll also have to be thoughtful to create sufficient visual contrast to direct attention without completely overwhelming your audience.

If you find yourself fighting with the existing slide template, look for avenues to delicately provide feedback to those requiring or creating it. Alternatively, you may have leeway to make minor changes directly.

Practice designing in style

As we've discussed, there are benefits to integrating branding into your visual communications. However, eloquently incorporating these elements into your slides takes practice. Here's an opportunity to practice in a low-risk manner through an exercise excerpted from my second book, *storytelling with data: let's practice!*

Identify two recognizable brands. You might choose company brands or sports teams, for instance. It will be more fun and increase the learning potential if you pick two that are quite different from each other in terms of style. Research images related to the brand and list ten adjectives that describe the look and feel of each.

Next, select a slide you've created. Remake it twice, incorporating components of each of your chosen brands, respectively. After you've finished, compare the two iterations. How does each feel? Were you successful in bringing the adjectives you outlined to life? How would you generalize brand components to take into account when communicating? What are the benefits of doing so? Are there scenarios where it *doesn't* make sense to be consistent with branding?

In the event that multiple presentation templates are available to you, I suggest opting for the simplest. The emptier your starting point, the more flexibility you'll have when it comes to adding content to each slide. If no standard template exists, consider making one.

Let's discuss one of the first steps in that process.

Setting your own style: color

When you start from scratch, there are more decisions to make. This can be a fun but overwhelming process, particularly for those who aren't confident in their design ability. I *don't* recommend using the preset templates in your presentation software. They tend to be busy and use questionable color and font combinations.

Instead, start simple and find something from which to take inspiration. When I'm setting a new style for a slide deck, the first choice I'll often make is color. There are a number of online resources that can help with this. Adobe offers color combinations based on current trends and tools to build your own color palette at color.adobe.com. Google, as part of their Arts & Culture Experiments, provides palettes based on thousands of artworks at artsexperiments.withgoogle.com/artpalette. The US National Park Service circulates park-inspired color palettes on Twitter and Instagram tagged with #NPScolorforecasting. This is merely a sampling of resources for generating color schemes. There are also numerous online color palette generators that will extract colors from pretty much anything. For example, at degraeve.com/color-palette you can upload the URL of any image (a stock photo, a picture of your favorite shirt...the possibilities are endless!).

When selecting colors, keep your purpose in mind. Are you creating a template that will be the new standard across your company or team? If so, the color combination should work with the established logo and brand and be adaptable enough to meet multiple needs. On the other hand, if you are designing a bespoke presentation, choose colors that relate to the topic or match the mood or perceptions you wish to impart.

People are inclined to feel certain ways when elements of our visual communications are rendered in particular hues. Figure 5.1 shows common color associations held in the United States.

serious distinctive elegant bold powerful sophisticated expensive night death
 conservative classic responsible dull somberness authority neutral logical rich
 practical reserved trust authority dignity security confident classic stability trust
 calming patient cool water contentment trusting serene sophisticated water
 coolness healthy fertile freshness environmentally conscious nature reliable
 appetite calm soothing refreshing young youth friendly positive feelings sunshine
 surprise cowardice energetic caution fun cheeriness sunset exuberance
 spontaneous optimistic speed history autumn earthiness richness tradition
 conservative earthy wholesome delicious rich rustic warm natural rich refined
 tasty expensive luxurious aggression passion sexy strength powerful assertive
 vitality fear speed danger exciting playful tropical flirtatious romantic sweet
 tasting femininity innocence softness youthful sophistication mysterious
 spirituality dramatic wealth royalty youth creative romantic sentimental nostalgic

FIGURE 5.1 Common US color associations

Many color associations vary by region (for an overview, check out the “Colours in Culture” visualization by David McCandless at informationisbeautiful.net). Take into account how all of this plays into the colors you set in your template or that you select for a given communication.

Also include a sufficient variety of hues and intensities so you have options to make things visually distinct. I recommend incorporating black and a range of grays. These will provide options for using single-color emphasis as well as de-emphasizing select visual elements in your slides. We’ll revisit these strategies in the context of visual hierarchy and look at specific instances in Chapters 6 and 7.

Establishing the *storytelling with data* style

I created the *storytelling with data* company brand in 2010. It began with a simple blue text title on my blog. Both color and font were extracted from Microsoft Excel's standard options, where I made all my graphs. When I decided I needed a logo, I made it myself, integrating a bar chart into the words and updating the font from Arial to Avenir to match my first book. In time, we also shifted from the basic blue to a bolder, brighter version.

While the logo has gradually changed over time, the adjectives I'd use to describe our brand remain steadfast: *approachable, accessible, clean, clear, consistent, encouraging, friendly, human, polished, quality, simple, thoughtful, trusted, and welcoming*. These guide both how we act and how we communicate visually. We have set slide templates that are used for our workshops and often play with fresh presentation designs for new content. The TRIX case study design that I walk you through in this chapter is an archetype of the latter.



FIGURE 5.2 The *storytelling with data* logo

Once you've selected your color palette, add the colors directly to your slide-ware application. You can watch a video tutorial where I walk you through how to do this at storytellingwithyou.com/slidelcolors.

Setting your own style: font

There is an entire field that focuses on the design of printed materials called **typography**. Fonts are an important component. I am by no means an expert on this topic (nor am I on color; the advice I share is based on my practical use of these design aspects). Most typographers would shudder at the fact that I employed the commonly used Arial font for as long as I did! I believe this is another facet of communication—like many others we’ve covered—where it makes sense to start simple and, if needed, get more nuanced over time.

Learn more about typography

Font, or typeface, also invokes feeling, albeit typically to a lesser degree than color unless it’s something especially stylized like *script* or **PERMANENT MARKER**. A common early decision when choosing a font is whether to opt for a serif (with a decorative stroke that extends off the end of a letterform, such as Times New Roman) or sans serif variety (the more minimalist Avenir font that this book is set in is a sans serif typeface).

There are three main ways to obtain fonts: system fonts, free fonts, and professional fonts. System fonts are the ones available on your computer (Arial, mentioned previously, is a prime example of this). You can download free fonts at no cost from fonts.google.com. Professional fonts are those you must pay to use.

An excellent resource and entertaining read if you’d like to learn more about typography is *Butterick’s Practical Typography* (practicaltypography.com).

When it comes to font in business communications, I am an advocate of prioritizing legibility above all else. I recommend selecting a simple typeface and ensuring the text is sized so that it is easy to read. I tend to prefer sans serif fonts due to their clean look. I opt for font families that have a markedly distinct bold option to use for sparing word or phrase emphasis. I don't tend to mix different font families, but I have done this on occasion (my second book, *storytelling with data: let's practice!*, was printed in a mix of Avenir and a bespoke handwritten font to promote a less formal feel).

If I'm going to share the slides I create or if they'll be projected from someone else's computer, I'll select a system font (one that is pre-installed). When slides are viewed from another computer and a special font hasn't been downloaded, a system font will be automatically substituted. This both means the design will differ from what was intended and other formatting problems may arise since fonts vary in size. To avoid these issues, save the file as a read-only PDF before sharing or opt for a system font if the deck will be presented. In cases where your slides will only be viewed from your own computer, you have more options.

I have a hard time choosing fonts without seeing slides formatted in them. If I plan to use a new one, I often postpone my selection until I'm actively creating slides in order to compare different options side by side. I'll outline the process I go through for the TRIX case study later in this chapter.

Make the slide master

At this point, if you have a company or team presentation template, make use of that and skip this step; move ahead to the *Set the structure* section later in this chapter.

If you don't have a standard template or you have decided to create something new, it's worth investing the time to make a slide master. The slide master stores information about the theme and slide layouts of a presentation.

This is where you input your chosen colors and fonts and also make decisions about the general layout of the slides. When designed well, the slide master helps bring a cohesive feel to presentations and makes individual slides faster to create.

Presentation tools

The most common slide applications that I encounter in a business setting are PowerPoint, Keynote, and Google Slides. No tool is inherently good or evil; how you use the product and present the materials you create with them determines whether your communication will be effective. My general advice is to get to know your chosen slideware so it doesn't constrain what you are able to do. If you encounter challenges, a good Google search will usually bring up numerous resources to help guide you.

I'll walk you through the process that I use to make a new slide master for a presentation. While my instructions refer to PowerPoint (the presentation software with which I am most familiar), you can apply a similar approach in any slide application.

Start with a blank slate

I begin by opening PowerPoint and creating a new presentation. Then I view the slide master and undo everything that is there. First, I delete all of the provided layouts (save those that Microsoft won't let me remove—the first two, which are the upper-leftmost Theme Slide and the Title Slide that immediately follows it). Then I delete each of the individual placeholders (for titles, bullets, date, page number, etc.) from the remaining two slides.

Why go through this work? I don't want layouts that have been designed by someone else that are meant to meet the basic requirements of many scenarios. Rather, I want to thoughtfully design slide layouts that will meet *my exact* needs for *my specific* situation.

After deleting everything that is there, I am left with two empty master slides: a blank slate. Next, I design these layouts and add the additional ones to meet my objectives. Together, these will become the template that I will use to create my slide deck.

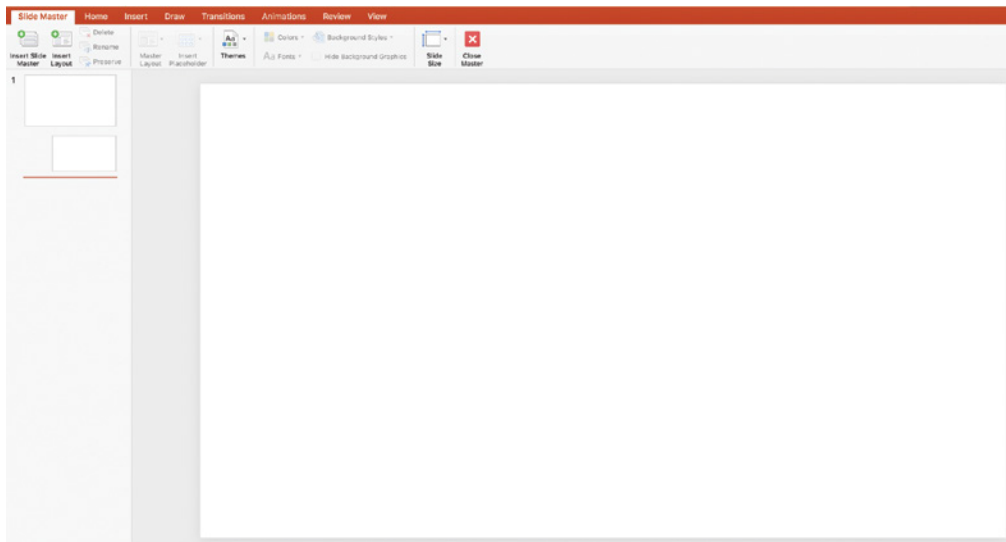


FIGURE 5.3 My blank slide master in PowerPoint

The upper-leftmost white rectangle in Figure 5.3 is where I'll set the overarching theme. Each element that is added to this slide (whether a static element or placeholder; I'll walk through that distinction momentarily) will show up on every other layout in the given theme. When we want to depart from this, we can cover up individual pieces as necessary. This will make more sense in the context of an actual example, so let's build a slide master, starting with that top theme slide.

Design the theme slide and content slides

Let's assume I'm preparing to give a presentation on behalf of my company, *storytelling with data*. This means a number of design decisions have already been made. I use the SWD color palette, which includes the bright blue from our logo and a number of complementary hues. I'll stick with the Avenir font family, the typeface you are reading now (a free font that I already have installed on my computer).

I'll keep things simple. On my theme slide, I'll introduce a placeholder for the title at the top left. I'll format the color to be blue and select Avenir Medium for the font. On the bottom right, I'll add an icon version of my company's logo.

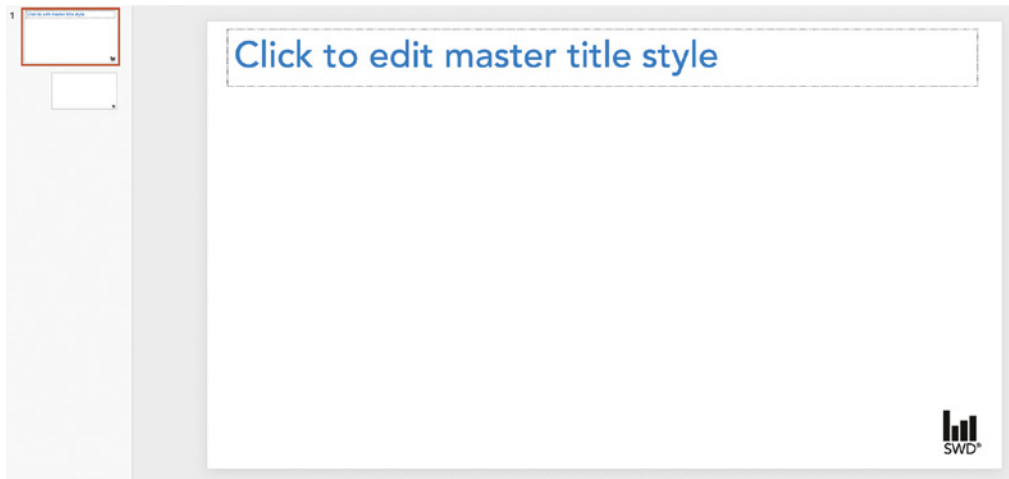


FIGURE 5.4 Slide master theme slide

Now I have my theme slide set. When I insert a new content layout, it will look exactly like this. If I want this exact formatting every time a new slide is created, I can add a single new layout and stop there.

If I'd like some different set formatting options from which to choose, I will add additional layouts and make the desired modifications to each. For example, I could include an option that has black title text instead of blue. Perhaps on

occasion, I'll want a version that *doesn't have* the black SWD logo: I can place a white rectangle over this element on the given layout slide to achieve this. Figure 5.5 shows my master slide view after I've added a layout that mirrors my theme slide and the two slide variations I've just described.

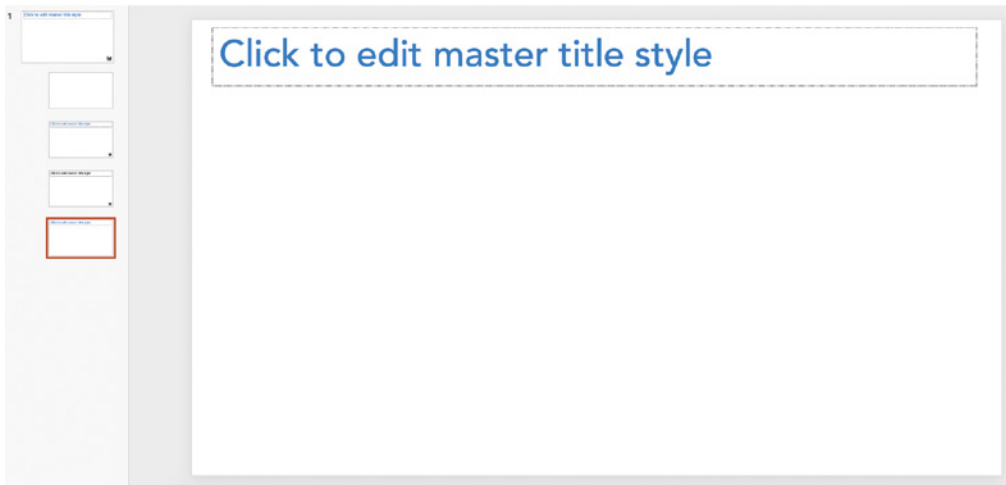


FIGURE 5.5 Slide master with various content slides

Notice that the second-from-the-top slide is still blank. This is my title slide. Let's design it, plus some divider slides, next.

Design title and divider slides

What comes first in a presentation deck? The title slide. If we think ahead to our delivery of the materials, it's possible that this initial slide will be visible for some amount of time—projected onto a screen as people walk into the meeting room, log on to a virtual meeting, or take their seats at a conference. As a result of this, often it's our title slide that makes the first impression on our audience. Use it to set the stage visually for what's coming.

The title slide is where I first introduce my selected colors, font, possibly a logo or image, and other stylistic choices. I will use it to set expectations for the topic of my communication as well, an approach we'll review when we discuss use of words in Chapter 6.

In practical terms, within the slide master, I'll navigate to the title slide (which appears second, following the theme slide), insert a title element, and position the placeholder where I want it. I'll increase the size of the text and set the color and font to match my general style. If desired, I'll add a subtitle placeholder as well and format it to work with the rest of the design.

At this point, I'll typically also add divider slides. These can be used to emphasize a point or to visually demarcate the sections within my presentation. I like to have them in a variety of colors that work with my general theme. To achieve this, I'll add additional layouts and format the background in my desired colors (in this case, blue, orange, and teal). I'll also add title placeholders, then format and position them. I didn't love the contrast of black on color, so I reformatted both title placeholders and logo to be white for my divider slides. I'll add a plain black and a plain white layout (formatting the background to the desired color and covering the black logo on the white slide with a white rectangle), because I find I use these frequently.

Figure 5.6 shows my slide master after making all of these changes.

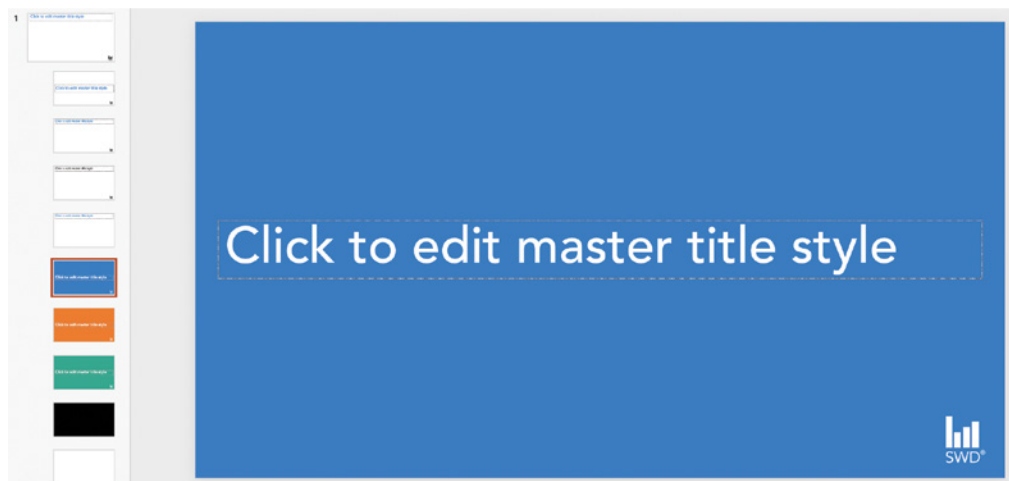


FIGURE 5.6 My new master slide template

I also renamed the theme and individual layouts. Now, when I exit the slide master and insert a new slide into my presentation, I choose which of my pre-set layouts to follow from my new theme, as shown in Figure 5.7.

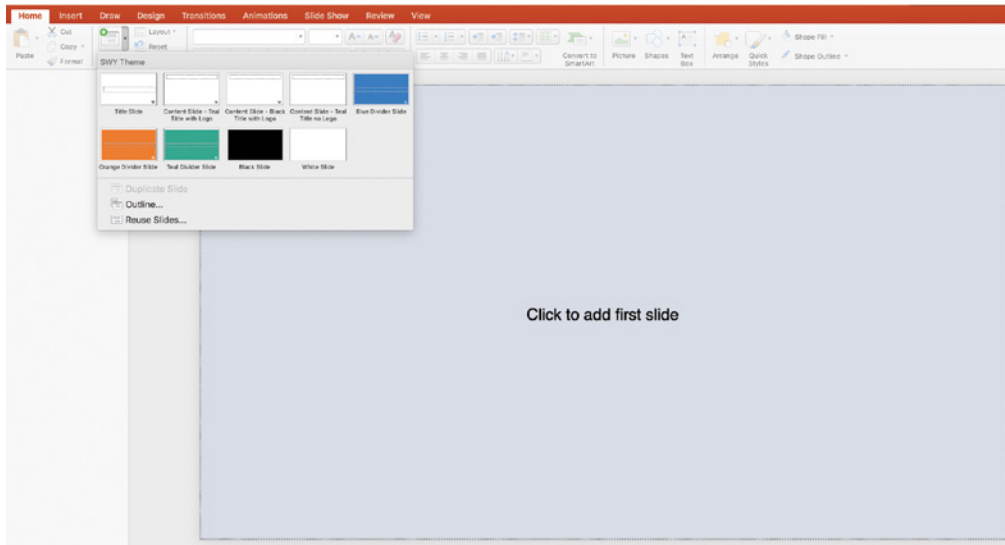


FIGURE 5.7 Select a layout from the new theme

While I've outlined this as a linear progression—creating one type of layout and then the next until you have a complete template—in reality, it's often an iterative process. I'll create my slide master and then make adjustments to those layouts as I start to build out actual content and see how it looks in my various set formats.

Your process and layouts may look different from mine, and that is totally fine! I share these specifics from my approach simply in case they are useful. One quirk of my process is that I tend not to create any layouts that have set content placeholders (bulleted text or a placeholder for graphs and images, to name a couple) because I like to position elements on each slide individually. That said, there are likely consistency and efficiency gains to be had, particularly if multiple people across your team or organization are using the template, and especially if different individuals will be contributing slides to a

single presentation. Design it all in a way that makes sense to you and works for your situation.

Once you've developed your slide master, it's time to set the structure of your presentation.

Set the structure

I'm a big advocate of building the skeleton for a presentation before adding content to individual slides. You already have the bones for this from the storyboarding and story formation processes that we discussed in Chapters 3 and 4. Now is the time to start to realize it in your presentation software. Setting up the structure after you've created your slide master but *before* putting content on your slides helps keep your attention on the overall flow. This way you don't get distracted when it is time to start fully fleshing out your content.

Title your slides

With your storyboard or narrative arc handy, create a new presentation using a provided template or the one you designed. Add a title slide. We'll discuss effective titling in Chapter 6 when we explore using words well, but for now title it with the topic. Add a content slide. Refer to your plan, and add what you've written on the first sticky note as the slide title. Fight the urge to add *anything else* to the slide at this point—this process of setting up the structure first allows you to continue to vet the overall approach through a different lens. If there's detail you feel you absolutely have to capture (for example, if a thought related to an individual slide strikes you and you don't want to lose it), add it to the slide notes of the given slide. Then you'll have it as reference once you do start to build content. Continue this process until you've transferred all the ideas from your curated sticky notes (or whatever method you used) into your presentation software. I'll share some examples later in the chapter.

Takeaway titles and horizontal logic

I am a big advocate of takeaway titles. We'll talk more about this concept in Chapter 6 (and look at a variety of examples), but here's a teaser to prompt you to think about it as you add initial titles to your slides. Identify the main point you wish to make on a given slide. Articulate it in a sentence. Work to make it more concise—aim for simple and direct. Once you've arrived at something that is clear and pithy, title your slide with it.

Transferring ideas from storyboard or story arc to slides makes this process easier given that you likely already framed the pieces of your narrative in a way that answers the question, "So what?" Continue to do this when you transition from stickies to slides, forming titles that don't set up the *what* (descriptive title) but rather the *why* (takeaway title) for the given content. When you read through only the titles of your deck, together they should convey your overarching story. This is called horizontal logic.

After completing this process, go back to the beginning of your deck. Flip through, reading the slide titles that you've just added. Does it accurately reflect what you want to communicate?

If you answered yes and have a short communication with a simple story arc, jump ahead and start to build content on the individual slides. In a longer presentation—and in particular if there are various facets to the story you want to tell—it may be worth creating and integrating a navigation scheme.

Create a navigation scheme

Like the table of contents in a book, a navigation scheme sets the structure of your presentation so others know what to expect and in what general order. Presentation creators often overlook this basic and important step. When you are creating a communication, you know it well, so it's easy to jump straight in. But your audience is never as close to your work as you are. Letting them know the general plan up front helps ground their expectations in helpful ways. As an added benefit, it keeps you, the presenter, on track both as you create and deliver the content as well.

In addition to setting the stage for what's coming, a navigation scheme employed well will also help orient people in the midst of content. When making use of one, I advocate introducing it somewhere close to the beginning. Then return to it as you transition from one section or topic to the next. In this manner, you can make it clear to others where you are in the presentation as it relates to both where you've been and where you're going.

Let's get more concrete. Presume that you're preparing a communication to present the results of a supplier analysis you've undertaken. You've plotted your story arc and divided the content into five sections. You could use a simple slide with numbers and text to introduce these topics. See Figure 5.8.

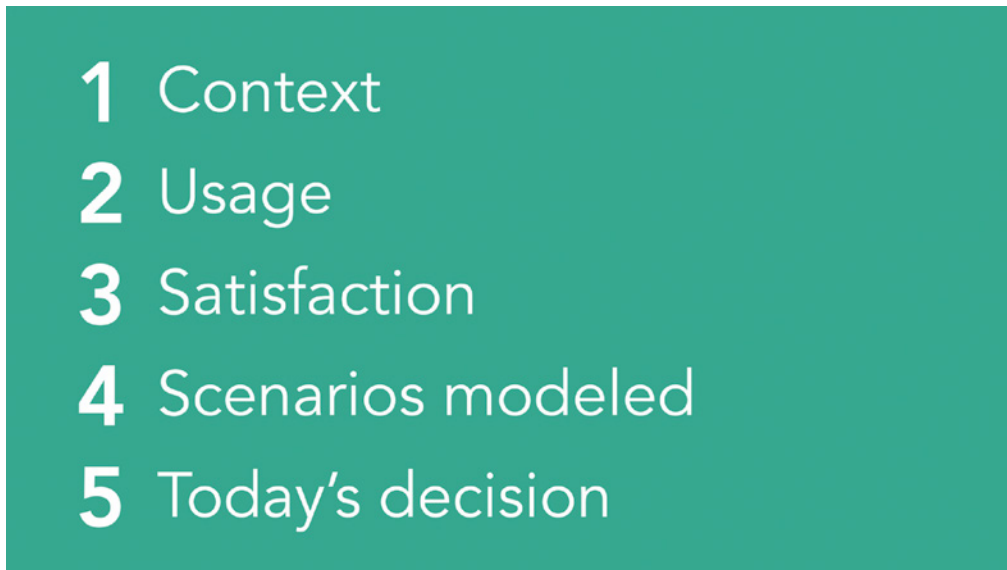


FIGURE 5.8 Navigation scheme from supplier analysis presentation

After talking through the particulars of section one with the various slides you will have built to assist you, you would repeat this slide, with some minor formatting adjustments that draw attention to the following topic. See Figure 5.9.

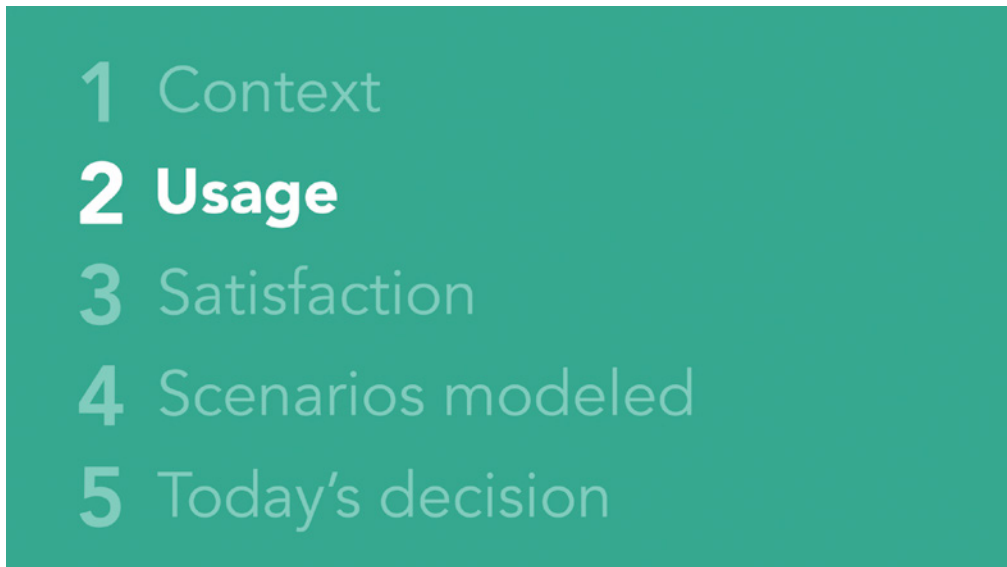


FIGURE 5.9 Transition into section 2

You'd follow a similar process to transition from each section to the next as you progress through your content.

The specific look and feel of your navigation scheme will vary by situation. For a business presentation, the slide you use as your navigation scheme might be simple numbers or text, as we've just seen. For a conference session, you likely have more leeway to be creative, perhaps integrating images or other visual stimuli. In the Tableau Conference presentation mentioned earlier in this chapter, I kicked things off with a story about my kids (made relevant to what I planned to cover in the session). I used images of them on a slide to introduce three lessons, then revisited this slide when I transitioned from one lesson to another. Figure 5.10 shows the navigation scheme that I introduced after my story to set up the three sections.



FIGURE 5.10 Navigation scheme from my Tableau conference presentation

After introducing the lessons briefly, I focused attention visually on the first one—Super Writer—to transition into the details.



FIGURE 5.11 Transition into first lesson

After the slides in this first lesson, I repeated the original slide, this time with attention drawn to the middle panel introducing the second lesson we learned from the Curious Cat. We'll look at this particular example again momentarily, where you'll be able to see this progression.

Whether simple or more creative, I recommend making your navigation scheme aesthetically distinct from the body of your communication. This acts as a visual cue to your audience (and you) that something is changing. Use one or more of the divider slides you designed in your slide master for this.

Vet the flow in slide sorter view

Whether using a navigation scheme or not, viewing your presentation framework in slide sorter view—where you see all the slides at once as small thumbnails—will give you yet another lens through which to see your planned content.

I recommend doing this after adding slide titles and then, if using one, again after incorporating your navigation scheme. When you've used a visibly distinct layout (a slide with colored background or images, as we just reviewed), this allows you to see chunks of planned content at a glance. Assess relative order and see whether the length of each section feels balanced for what you need to get across and how you want to spend your time.

Figure 5.12 shows an early slide sorter view for my Tableau Conference presentation.

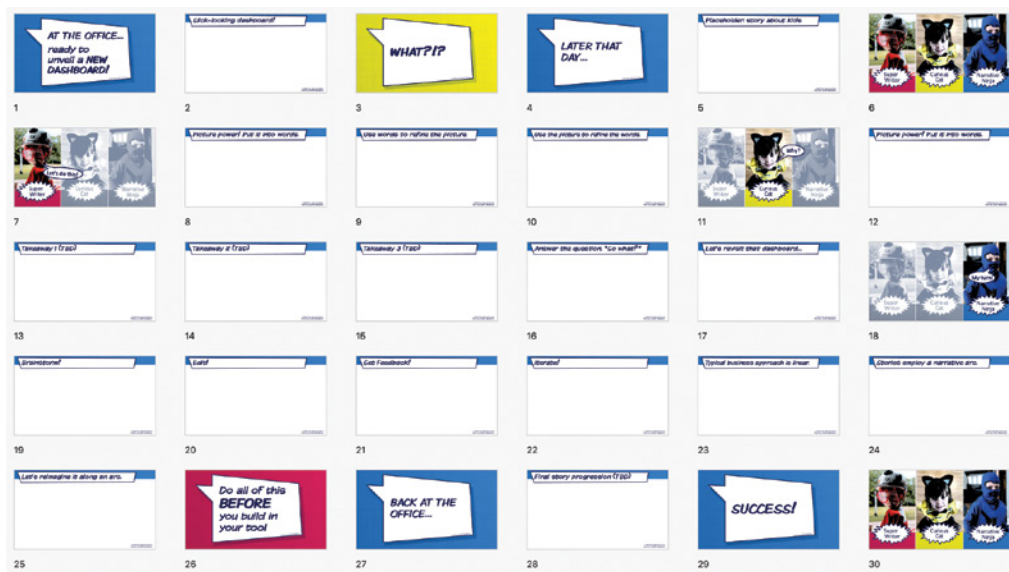


FIGURE 5.12 Slide sorter view

My initial framework was a combination of divider slides (those with colored backgrounds and cartoon-like text), my navigation scheme (the repeated image with my kids, with respective emphasis), and blank slides with only titles or placeholder titles for planned content. A number of these placeholder slides turned into longer progressions—my final slide deck was 174 slides! Building this structure up front helped ensure that it all came together in a way that made sense.

Seeing and talking through your presentation outline in slide sorter view helps you continue to assess your approach. This is another excellent place to seek input and refine. Confirm you are on track before you start building individual slide content. We will turn our attention there soon.

Before we do, let's look at one more example.

Set the style & structure: TRIX case study

Now that you've read an overview of my process, let's see how it plays out step by step in the case study we've been working our way through.

My first step is to determine the style. I start completely from scratch. To anonymize this example for use here, I invented the TRIX brand (a step to ensure that the original company, product, and team remain undisclosed). I'm pulling back the curtains on this piece to detail my inspiration for the colors: an image of Arches' famous red rock formations in Moab, Utah, shared as part of the National Park Service's #NPScolorforecasting. (You may recognize this color scheme—I liked it so much that it influenced the design of this book!)



FIGURE 5.13 Color inspiration from #NPScolorforecasting

Figure 5.14 shows the logo I created based on the color palette I pulled from the image. I even took inspiration from the way the color palette is shown in the original image, integrating multi-colored rectangles into my logo!



FIGURE 5.14 Logo created using Arches image colors

I program the brand colors into PowerPoint for easy use (like I did in the instructional video mentioned earlier in the chapter). While I used a bold font for the logo, I know I want something easier to read and with more options for creating contrast in the main typeface of my presentation. I save that decision to make for when I create my slide template so I can compare different options side by side.

In the slide sorter view in PowerPoint, I delete all of the preset formats and start with a blank slate. First, I design the title slide. I play with different placements of the logo and various background colors. In the end, I opt for a mostly white slide, with a large blue rectangle for my title and subtitle. See Figure 5.15.



FIGURE 5.15 Title slide

Next, I try various font options. I consult *Practical Typography*. I want a system font so I don't encounter issues if the deck is shared. Author Matthew Butterick isn't a fan of system fonts due to their overuse; however, he does indicate a handful that are "generally tolerable." I add text to my slide title and quickly test out each of the 21 typefaces on the tolerable list, saving a copy of the ones I like the most.

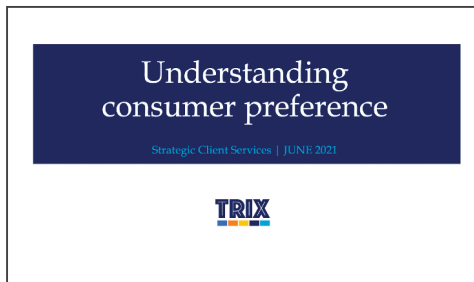
Book Antiqua**Gill Sans MT****Helvetica Neue****Optima**

FIGURE 5.16 Comparing fonts

I narrow my options down to a single serif font (Book Antiqua) and three sans serif fonts. I'm after something that feels fun but professional that will stand out against my strong color palette. The serifs of Book Antiqua feel too formal. Helvetica Neue is quite similar to Arial, which I've used a lot in the past. I want to go in a different direction. The thinness of Optima means there's less contrast of white text on a dark background, which I don't love. By process of elimination, I choose Gill Sans MT.

After setting my title slide and deciding on a font, I design the content slide. I am a fan of a prominent title space at the top of each slide. This can be used to highlight the primary takeaway. I add a placeholder for this title text and leave the rest of the slide blank, save a small logo at the bottom right. My audience in the Western part of the world is conditioned to start at the top left of my page or screen and move their eyes in a zigzagging “z” shape. This means the bottom right of my slide is the last place they’ll look—the perfect spot for a logo to remind them of the brand without it being a distraction from the other elements that I’ll add to each slide.



FIGURE 5.17 Content slide

I begin the dark blue title bar at the far left of the page. This is to grab your attention and draw it rightwards to the title. Rather than continue the title bar across the entire slide, I stop it short, leaving some white space on the right.

I right align the TRIX logo at the bottom in this same spot. This leaves me a natural margin on the right-hand side of each slide. I'll leave the areas on the right and to the left of the title text and below the bottom of the logo free of elements when I design my actual slides. A clean margin around each will ensure there's enough whitespace for the slides to breathe.

I design my divider slides. These are simple full-color slides with basic text placeholders. I create one in each of the Arches theme colors. Figure 5.18 shows the dark blue version.

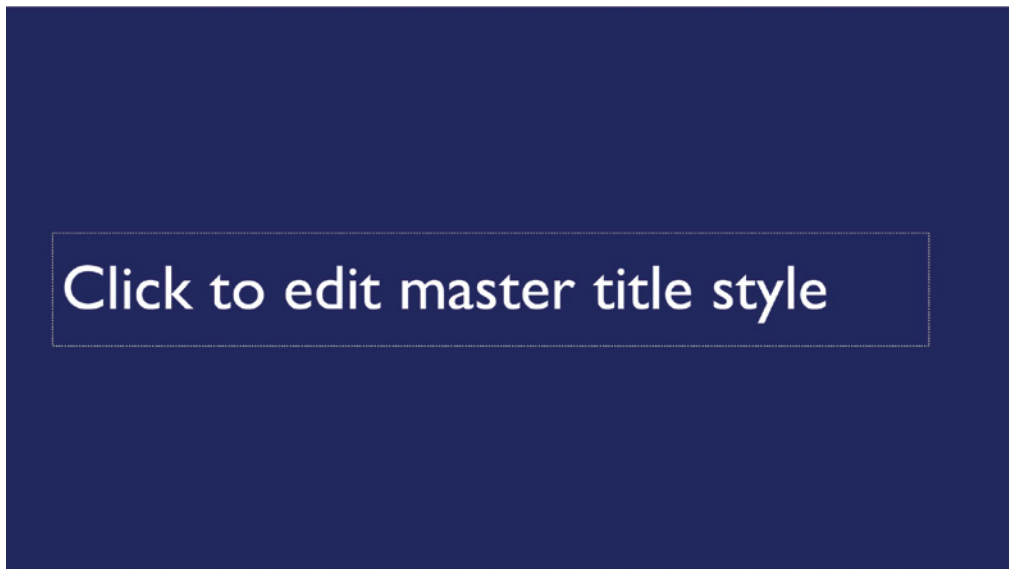


FIGURE 5.18 Divider slide

At the end of this process, I have a template that I name Arches Theme. It contains a title slide; content slide; section slides in bright blue, orange, yellow, dark blue, and turquoise; a plain white slide; and a plain black slide.

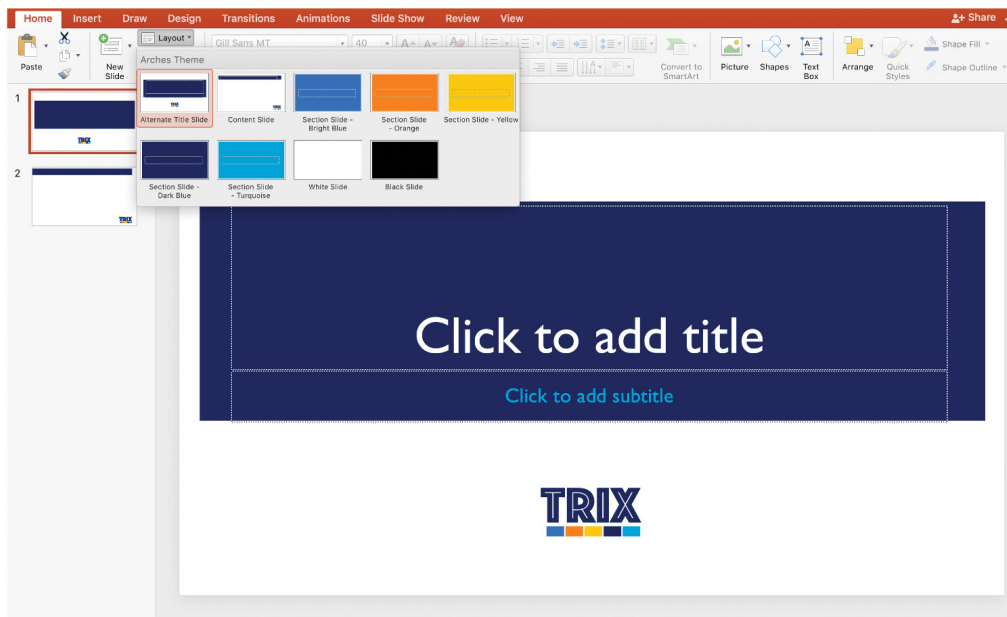


FIGURE 5.19 My new Arches Theme

Next, I start a new presentation using my Arches Theme and begin working on my navigation scheme.

You may recall an idea I had and abandoned as part of my low-tech planning process: a choose-your-own-adventure story. I still have this in my mind as I start playing with a navigation scheme. I want to be able to visually illustrate that we took a long and winding path—diving into numerous aspects, collecting and analyzing data thoroughly, to come up with our ultimate recommendation.

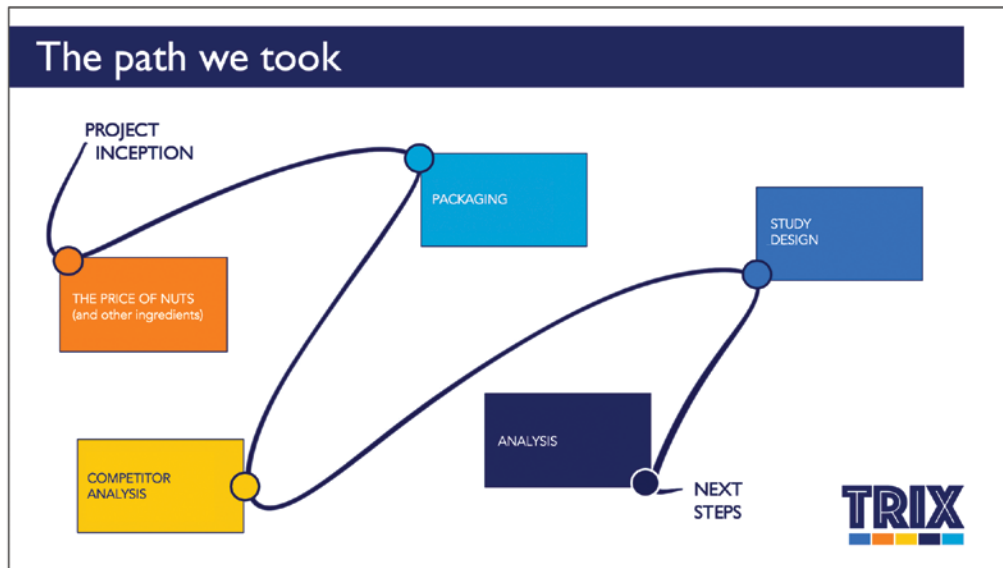


FIGURE 5.20 Initial navigation scheme

I create the slide shown in Figure 5.20. Still toying with the idea of building this full detail into my deck, I add divider slides for each of the sections shown in my navigation scheme, then add titled slides within each section. Figure 5.21 shows the slide sorter view after doing this.

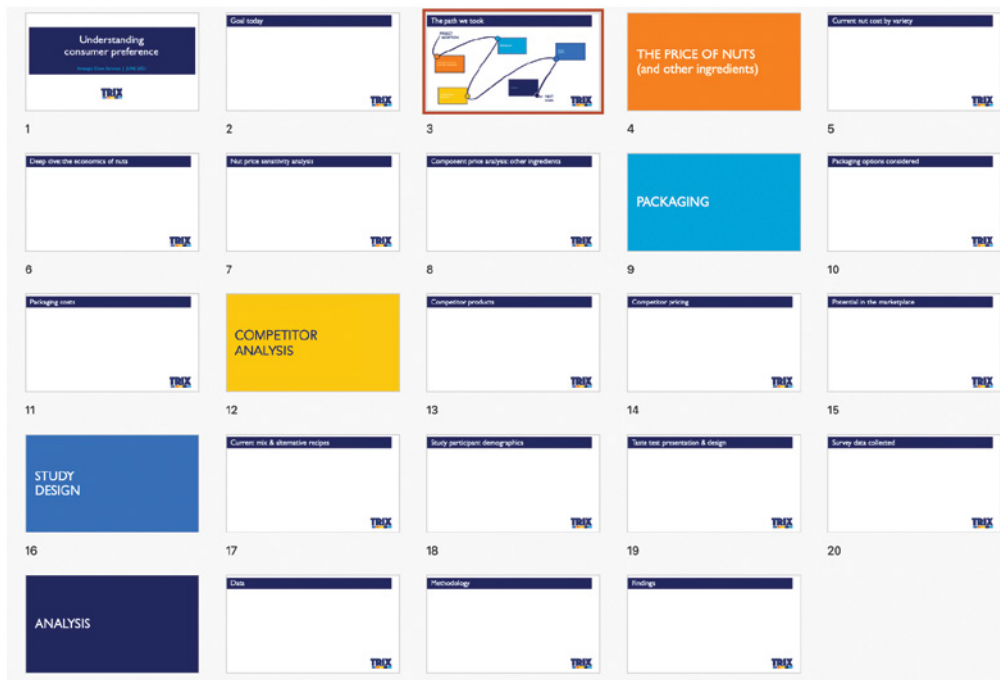


FIGURE 5.21 Initial slide sorter view

Seeing the content mapped out this way and turning back to my story arc, I realize that I've gone a little off track. Rather than go through all of this detail, I could use the slide I had initially planned for my navigation scheme to talk through at a high level the robust process we undertook. I'll let my audience know that the full detail is in the appendix (where I'll repeat the navigation scheme and use the color-coded divider slides to denote the respective sections), and that I will be happy to walk through any of that—*after* I tell them the TRIX story.

Turning back to my arc, I plot out the slides that will tell this story, shown in Figure 5.22.

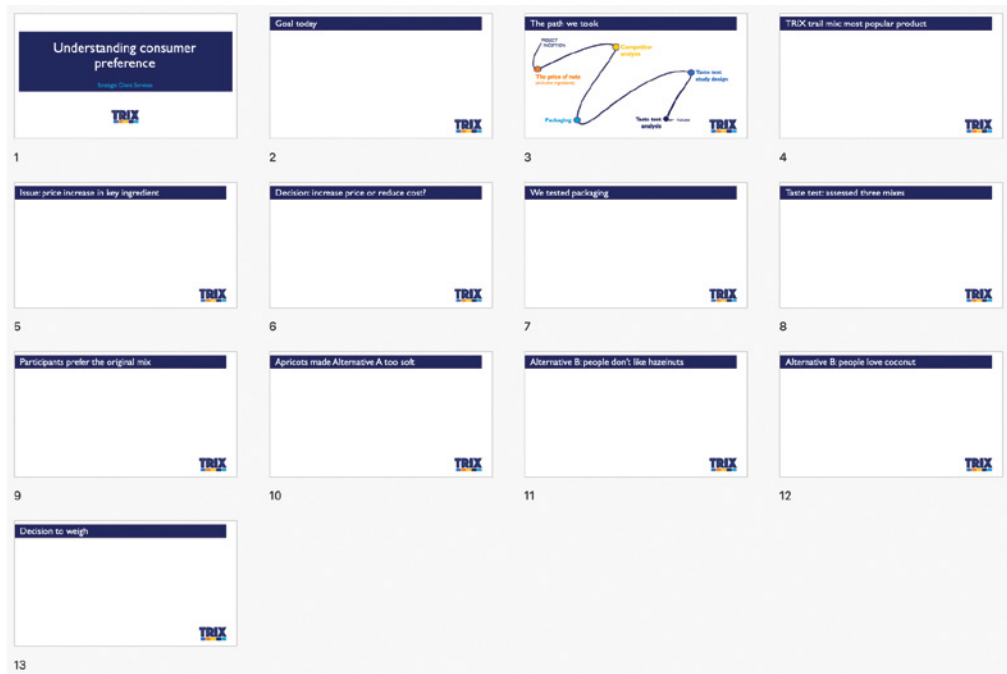


FIGURE 5.22 Slide sorter view of my refined story

I'll start by setting the context, sharing the goals for the project generally and for our meeting specifically. Then I'll use a variation of the visual path I created to discuss the numerous lines of work we undertook at a high level. The rest of my slides will tell the TRIX story. Here are the slide titles from slide four onward for easy reading:

- TRIX trail mix: most popular product
- Issue: price increase in key ingredient
- Decision: increase price or reduce cost?
- We tested packaging
- Taste test: assessed three mixes
- Participants prefer the original mix
- Apricots made Alternative A too soft
- Alternative B: people don't like hazelnuts
- Alternative B: people love coconut
- Decisions to weigh

Now with my slide style and structure slides in place, it's time. Let's begin creating the actual slide content.

We'll start with a basic—and important—element: words.

Takeaway title

- supporting point 1
- supporting point 2
- supporting point 3



chapter 6

say it with words

Words on slides play a critical role in our visual communications. They can pique interest, set expectations, illuminate, explain, and reinforce. Words can also overwhelm, complicate, irritate, and distract.

We all use words on a daily basis in our speaking and our writing. But the way to employ text in your presentations doesn't necessarily follow the conventions of these activities. Have you ever thought critically about how to best title a presentation? Or debated whether the number of words is too few or too many on a given slide?

Perhaps it's because words seem simple that many people don't give much thought to them. In a presentation setting, when we *don't* carefully examine how we use our words, they can easily work against us. Most of us have experienced a common abuse: the dreaded slide filled with bulleted text. We'll dissect why this technique doesn't work and introduce alternative strategies. There are more nuanced considerations when it comes to utilizing words wisely, too. Harnessing the power of words in our presentation materials is the focus of this chapter.

Let's begin by exploring how to use words to title our visual communications.

Words to title

You’ve surely set a presentation or slide title before. How did you approach it? For many, the tendency is to opt for a *descriptive* title—one that introduces the topic. There’s nothing inherently wrong with this; however, I see it as a missed opportunity. We can use words in powerful ways to title our presentations and slides.

Foreshadow with your presentation title

Let’s start at the beginning of your deck, with the title slide. Descriptive presentation titles would be things like “Supplier Analysis,” “Competitive Landscape Update,” or “Quarterly Business Review.”

As we discussed in Chapter 5, the presentation title is the first thing others encounter in your communication. Use it to capture your audience’s attention, foreshadow an interesting point you’re going to discuss, or introduce something you want to prime others to ponder. Consider the following titles: “Changing our supplier strategy could reduce costs,” “We are winning across the competitive landscape,” or “(Mostly) strong results last quarter.” How do they compare to the descriptive ones listed previously?

There are a couple important distinctions to note between the titles I just suggested and those introduced in the prior paragraph. Instead of topics, the revised titles are more complete thoughts. In some cases they are even full sentences. Related to this, while the original titles were written in title case (where the first letter of each word is capitalized), the modified iterations are in sentence case (the first letter of the first word is capitalized, and the rest are written in lower case). This is personal preference, but sound logic encourages that the title be a full idea and go beyond a simple topic. The reworked titles each foreshadow something about the forthcoming content. In some cases, the revised titles bring the audience (and presenter) into the picture, through use of words like “our” and “we,” making things more personal and less abstract.

If moving entirely away from descriptive titles feels like too big of a leap, try a combined approach. Make your primary title descriptive but add a foreshadowing subtitle (or vice versa). Figure 6.1 shows what the title slides could look like for the series of titles I've introduced, as well as a bonus fourth example. The first one (upper left) has a descriptive main title and explanatory subtitle, while the others illustrate the opposite, emphasizing the more intriguing part but also keeping the descriptive title present to help set the context.

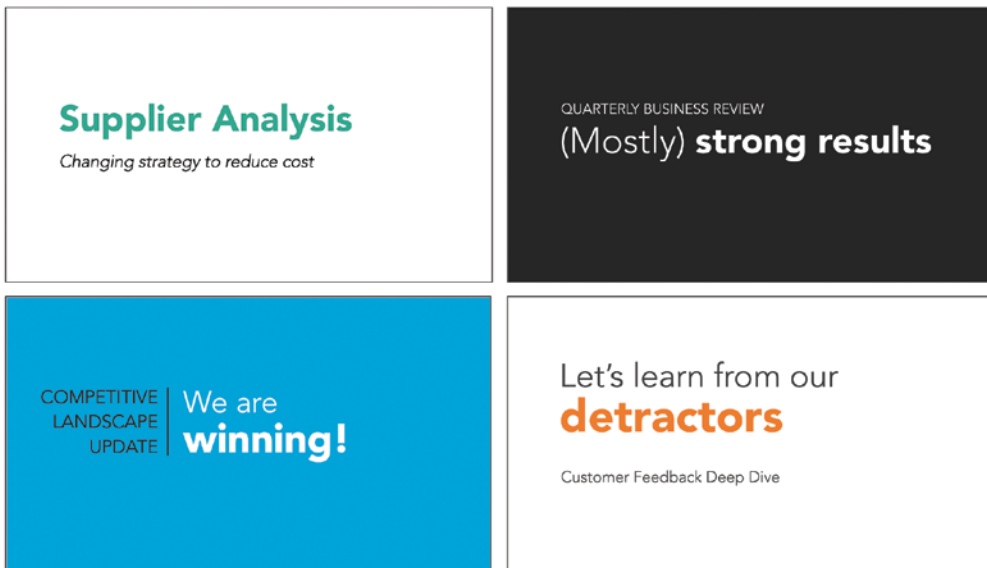


FIGURE 6.1 Business presentation title slides

The preceding examples are business-meeting-type titles. Imagine how the same shift from descriptive to more refined titling would work in a formal presentation setting, too. Instead of titling my conference keynote with the topic “Data Storytelling,” I might use “Bringing data to life through pictures and story.” This provides a peek into what I’ll illustrate and how I’ll inspire. View that actual presentation title slide, together with a few others I have used (including the Tableau Conference presentation referenced in Chapter 5), in Figure 6.2.



FIGURE 6.2 Conference presentation title slides

Whereas the business title slides simply featured text and perhaps a prominent color or two, there's often more freedom for creativity in conference presentation design. There are two noteworthy differences that I observe when comparing and contrasting Figures 6.1 and 6.2. First, there is greater variety in typeface. Whereas a business presentation likely leverages your company's chosen font (mine do—those shown each use Avenir), there's more room to play and try different styles in a conference setting, where eye-catching is a reasonable goal. An additional distinction is the integration of pictures or other visual elements into some of the conference presentation title slides. Whereas I don't typically suggest this in an ordinary business meeting, this can work well for materials delivered from stage. We'll talk more about the use of images in each of these settings in Chapter 8.

Communicate the key takeaway with your slide title

Another important set of titles to think about is your slide titles. Similar to what we have discussed with presentation titles, I find that people often default

to descriptive titles for their slides. More missed opportunities! If this is your habit, break it. Determine what you want others to remember about what you will say or show and title your slide with that. I refer to this as the **takeaway title**. It is helpful to start by articulating your main point in a single, complete sentence. Then shorten it as necessary, both to make it pithy and so it fits cleanly in the space. Avoid slide titles that extend onto multiple lines, which look messy and compete for attention with what you are saying.

Let's make this concrete through an example. Consider the descriptive slide title "Net Promoter Score." The Net Promoter Score, or NPS, is a common metric used in voice of customer analytics. The higher the NPS, the better. Imagine that I turn the primary idea I want to express on a given slide into the following sentence: "NPS has increased; however, when we dig deeper, we see an increasingly polarized customer base, with a higher proportion of both promoters and detractors than earlier in the year." While I might say those words, they would take up more room than I'd like at the top of my slide. I will adapt this into something punchier for my slide title, such as, "NPS up; however, customers are increasingly polarized." Or if I really want to emphasize the latter point, I could take things a step further, with something like, "Concern: increasingly polarized customer base." Then the fact that NPS has increased is something I can address as context but with clear emphasis on the area in need of attention.

A good takeaway title allows me to set people's expectations. As I illustrated with the NPS example, we can use a slide title to let others know how they should feel about the topic. You may also use the slide title to prompt the action you seek. Incorporate action words like *understand*, *discuss*, or *decide* to make it clear to your audience what exactly you want them to do. Priming with titles helps your audience get focused and act in the way that you desire. You'll see more of this in Chapter 7.

Let's revisit horizontal logic

Do you recall the concept of horizontal logic introduced in Chapter 5? We discussed it as a way to set the structure of your presentation. Now, with a better understanding of the takeaway title, is a great time to review it. We've discussed how important effective titling is for a given slide. When you've crafted a thoughtful narrative flow and employ takeaway titles on each slide, you can read only the slide titles of your presentation to get the overarching story. If you test this and it doesn't work, it may indicate where you are missing a piece or need transitional content or additional fine-tuning.

Now that we've covered thoughts related to presentation and slide titles, let's shift to some strategies for using text as primary slide content.

Words as content

Sometimes it feels like every slide we create should have a slick diagram, image, or graph. But words themselves can *be* content. Don't overlook the power of simple text.

One way to bring story structure directly into presentation design is to think of the slides we will create along the path of the story we plan to tell. As a reminder, Figure 6.3 shows the narrative arc (introduced in Chapter 4).

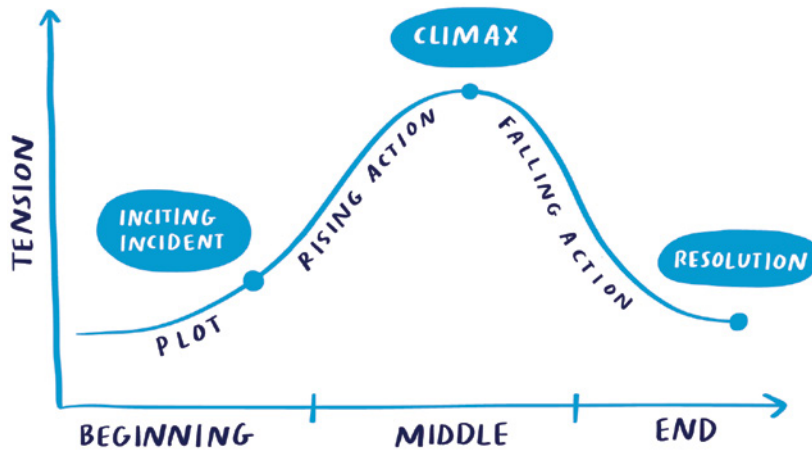


FIGURE 6.3 The narrative arc

Let's consider what text slides could look like along this path.

The story begins: plot slides

At the onset of our communication, there is often context to set. Perhaps you want to remind people where things left off when you last met, create common ground by bringing those who haven't been involved in the project up to speed, emphasize an important fact or stat, or simply let others know what you plan to talk about and why.

Words can help you do each of these things. That said, it is important to keep in mind that the majority of those words will be through what you say, not what you show.

Let's first look at a few examples of **sparing text**. When there are only a few words on a slide, those few words feel important. That's the power of blank space at play (the limited elements that *aren't* blank space stand out). When you have something critical to say, also putting *only* those words in text on their own slide both reinforces what you've said and helps ensure the important point isn't missed. Perhaps there is a notable number to highlight:

“Only 1 in 10 customers would recommend our service to their friends and family.” Think of how that would feel if you underscore this context by making it the sole text on an otherwise blank slide.

Figure 6.4 shows a couple of iterations of what this could look like. Note the different design decisions made in each, and contemplate when and why you would choose one version over the other.

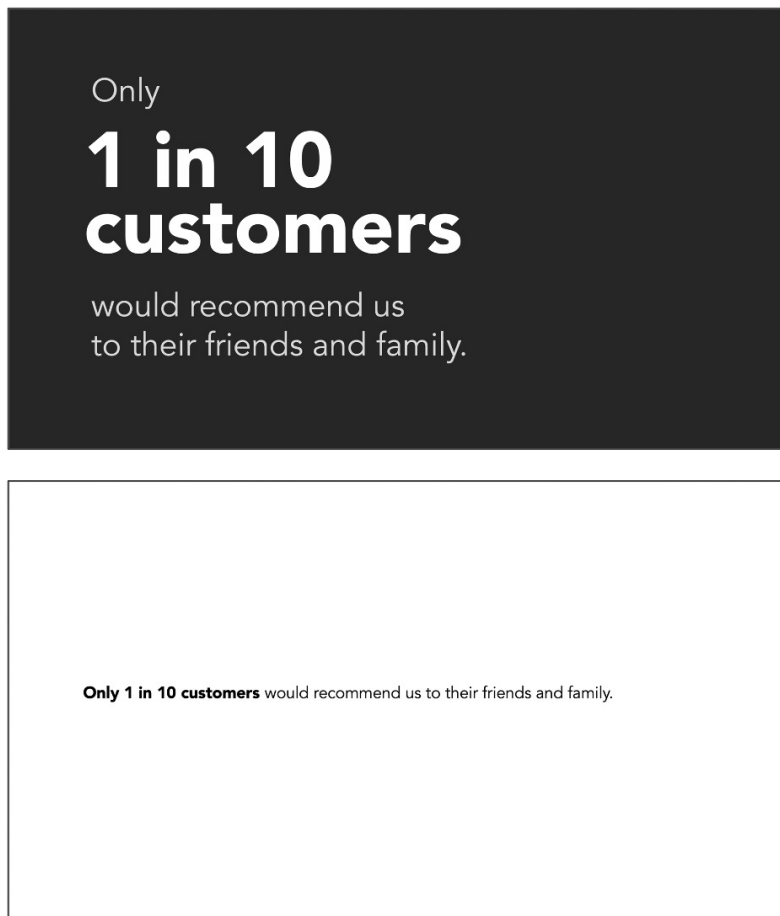


FIGURE 6.4 Sparing words on slides

As another example of sparse words on slides to set the stage, think back to the Big Idea that was introduced in Chapter 2. We discussed it primarily as a tool for you to become clear and concise on your message. However, once you've taken the time to form it, it may also make sense to communicate it directly to your audience. One way to do this is by devoting a slide to it.

Imagine that my Big Idea is: *We have an opportunity to achieve high patient satisfaction at a reasonable cost by shifting our supplier strategy.* Given this, I might create a slide like the following.

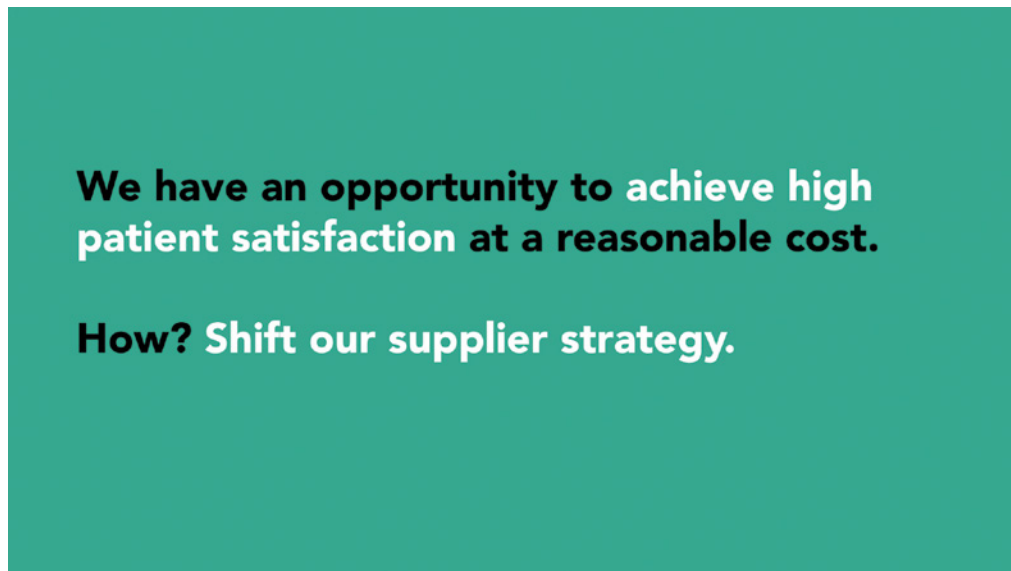


FIGURE 6.5 Big Idea on a slide

Depending on how I want to approach it, I might begin with a slide that shows only the first sentence to set the context (the opportunity we face). Then I can decide whether to foreshadow where I'd like to drive the conversation or if it will make sense to build to it over the course of the overarching story. I often use my Big Idea as an introduction to the rest of my content before I return to it at the end. Using it up front helps set expectations. Returning to it after the full details have been revealed can drive robust discussions among stakeholders

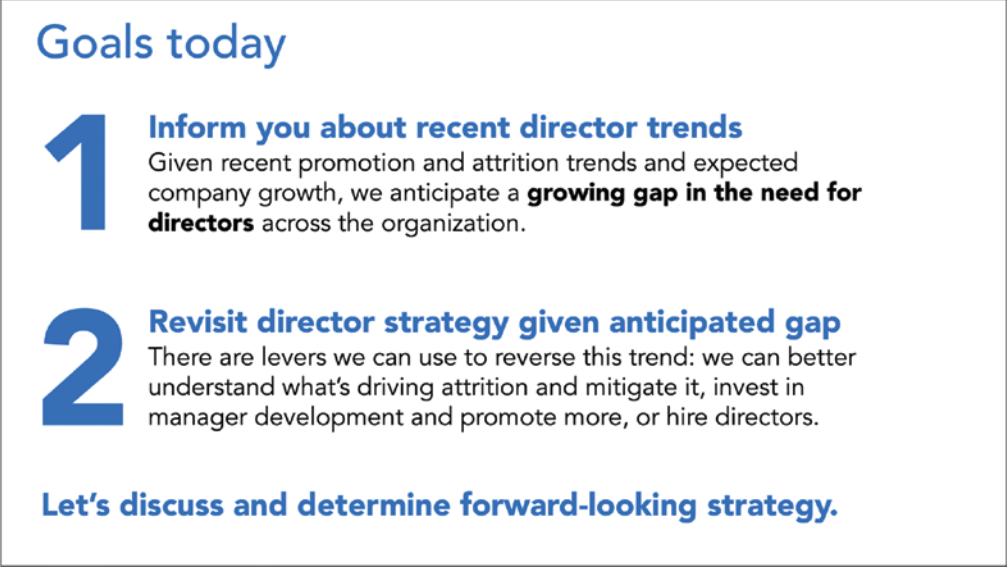
focused on the issue at hand or help them frame thoughtful questions. The repetition is also useful to reinforce the main point so that people are able to recall and repeat it more easily.

Create visual hierarchy on your slides

Thoughtfully establishing visual hierarchy on a slide means designing the information so that not all elements are treated equally. Highlight the most important aspects so they stand out and garner attention. This can be achieved through size, boldface, sparing color, or placement on the page. While you draw attention sparingly, also work to push less critical pieces to the background so that they are there for reference without distracting. In the case of text, this can be accomplished through use of gray, smaller size, and de-emphasizing placement at the bottom of the slide. This way of visually signaling to the audience how to process information helps denser content from overwhelming by making it scannable. We'll look at a number of instances of this with words in this chapter and in our data slides in Chapter 7.

We've seen a couple illustrations of sparing words on slides. But how should we approach it when there are more than a few words we'd like to share? People can't read and listen simultaneously. If they've started reading, it means they've stopped listening. You don't want to compete for attention. Does this mean we can't use more than a few words on a slide? No. It does mean we need to intentionally design and present—either formatting our slide to make it easily scannable, only showing some text at a time, or pausing to give others time to read. Let's look at an example.

Figure 6.6 shows a plot slide. It's intended to create a common understanding of the purpose of the meeting.



Goals today

- 1 Inform you about recent director trends**
Given recent promotion and attrition trends and expected company growth, we anticipate a **growing gap in the need for directors** across the organization.
- 2 Revisit director strategy given anticipated gap**
There are levers we can use to reverse this trend: we can better understand what's driving attrition and mitigate it, invest in manager development and promote more, or hire directors.

Let's discuss and determine forward-looking strategy.

FIGURE 6.6 More words on a slide, formatted for easy scanning

A slide like Figure 6.6 could be used early in my presentation to introduce the general structure of my content and set clear expectations for what I hope to accomplish. There are many words on this slide—some might argue too many. However, I've taken careful steps to make the content scannable. People can quickly read just the colored and bold text to get the gist. Note that this approach does give me the ability to have additional context present, which is useful in the scenario where I'm worried I'll forget something important or if I'm preparing content that someone else will be presenting. You can also imagine a lighter version of this slide, where I remove most or all of the smaller black text (which would then become my planned speaking notes).

Don't use your slides as a teleprompter!

Perhaps the most common instance of words employed *ineffectively* in presentations is the dreaded slide filled with bulleted text. I'd venture to bet that anyone who makes presentations has created one of these slides (I know I have). Most of us have also experienced this as an audience member, and it is painful. That's because we read in our heads much faster than any presenter is able to read out loud. After we've scanned the text—not really listening since it's difficult to do that while we're reading—we tune back in to realize the presenter is still several bullets back. It's an invitation to turn our attention to something else!

If you find yourself making this type of teleprompter slide—whether for yourself or for someone else to present—stop. Determine for each bullet: what is the primary topic or main point? How could you state it in a pithy, or short and punchy, way? Put *that* on the slide and preserve the context by adding it to the speaker notes section below the slide. We'll look at a specific example in the case study at the close of this chapter.

We've looked at a few plot slides where the primary content is words. Let's examine what text slides look like once we get into the story.

The story continues: mid-story slides

While I find that most of the text slides I use are in the plot and ending of my presentations, there are definitely cases where mid-story slides have words as primary content, too. When this is the case, I typically employ one of three strategies: pause to let people read, reveal piece by piece, or selectively highlight. Let's look at each of these approaches.

Imagine there is a fantastic verbatim quote from one of our customers that we want to use to lend evidence to a point we're making. I could design a slide

like Figure 6.7. Before turning to it, I would say something along the lines of, “I’m going to ask you to take a moment to read a comment we recently received from one of our customers.”

Customers **love** the new scan feature

“ I’ve been using your calorie & fitness tracking app religiously since it was beta and sharing with all of my friends and family—I might be your all-time world-wide biggest fan! The ability to scan labels is a game changer. I don’t usually write reviews, but I feel like I must given how massively I’ve benefited.

FIGURE 6.7 Take a moment to read this comment

I’d put up the slide and then pause to allow my audience time to process it. In an in-person session, you can gauge how long it takes others to read by watching them: note when eyes stop moving back and forth. Or if you don’t have the benefit of seeing your audience, read the words yourself slowly in your head (more leisurely than you think is required—you can easily scan your words because you are familiar with them, whereas others encountering them for the first time will process more slowly). After a sufficient pause to allow their attention to return to you, make your point.

Alternatively, rather than show the entire quote at once, I could introduce it line by line or segment by segment. This technique works well when presenting virtually. The visual motion of text building gradually helps maintain viewers’ attention as you talk through it (we’ll take a closer look at this strategy with

more varied content in Chapter 7). Take care with this paced strategy, which might feel overly controlling in some scenarios.

As another approach, if I don't need my audience to read the *entire* quote to make my point, I can reduce the effort and time to process by selectively highlighting. This draws on the visual hierarchy concept introduced earlier in this chapter. Figure 6.8 shows two designs that employ selective highlighting to draw attention to a few choice words through color, size, and position.



FIGURE 6.8 Selective highlighting

Compare the two designs in Figure 6.8. What does each say to you when it comes to how you are meant to consume it? To me, the first iteration seems as though I'm meant to read it all while paying special attention to the bold black text, whereas with the second version, I'm inclined to believe I only need to read the blue text. In either case, I am able to make my point as the presenter sooner than the initial two strategies described. Just be aware when using this method that some people will still want to read everything and won't be fully attentive to you while they do so.

Using words well also comes into play when we are using other types of primary content for our mid-story slides (for example, together with graphs and diagrams). We'll explore the use of text to help make other visual content more easily understood in Chapter 7.

The story ends: closing slides

The end of your presentation is a great place to reiterate your primary take-away or concentrate attention on what you want your audience to do next. Words can help you do both of these things.

As I mentioned before, in the case where I've shared my Big Idea to set the stage early in my presentation, I'll often come back to it at the end. It's useful to reflect on where people are at during each of these points. When I introduce my message up front, it's before I've fully supported it; I've put forward an idea or foreshadowed where we're going, but not yet in a way that others will necessarily know what to do with it. Contrast this with the experience when I restate it later in my presentation. I've gone through the necessary detail and supporting evidence during the story I've been telling. Now, when I show my Big Idea again, if I've done my job well, my audience should be equipped to do something with it. Let's look at an example.

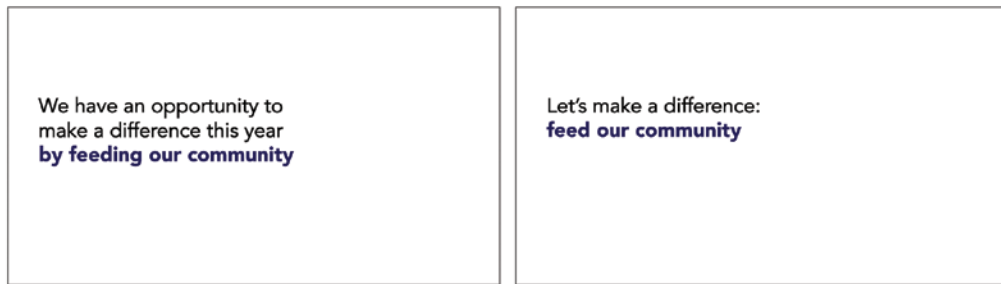


FIGURE 6.9 Big Idea slides for the beginning (left) and end (right) of my presentation

Early in my presentation, I will introduce the opportunity. Over its course, I can illustrate exactly what that means—the *who*, *when*, *why*, *where*, and *how* of the situation. At the end, I will return to my Big Idea, perhaps in a more direct and pithier manner (note how I’ve shortened the message on the right in Figure 6.9). I’ll leave this latter slide up after my planned content ends during the discussion that follows or as I answer questions.

Form a pithy, repeatable phrase

Repetition helps form a bridge from our short-term memory to our long-term memory. We can make use of this in the actual words we use to communicate our story in a business setting by articulating our main point in a pithy, repeatable phrase. Revisit the Big Idea explored in Chapter 2. Turn your Big Idea into a pithy, repeatable phrase. This can help you get clear on your goal when communicating and can also be incorporated into your materials to help increase memorability for your audience. The pithy, repeatable phrase is short and catchy, and it may incorporate alliteration. It doesn’t have to be cute. It does need to be memorable.

In a live presentation, you might begin with the pithy, repeatable phrase. You could also end with it, or you might weave it in different ways over the course of your presentation so that when your audience leaves the room, they’ve heard it a few times. This means they are both more likely to remember *and* be able to repeat it.

Let's consider another scenario. Imagine I've decided against beginning with my Big Idea in favor of building up to my recommendation. I use simple words to state the action I would like my audience to take: to discuss the recommendation that I have just made. See Figure 6.10.



FIGURE 6.10 Words to outline recommendation and drive discussion

We've looked at a number of slides where text is the primary content. These certainly aren't the only ways to use written words in our presentations but should give you some ideas upon which to build. Whether words or other content, for each slide you create, step back and think about what exactly you hope to accomplish. Then design the slide in light of how you'll be presenting, who your audience is, and how you can best achieve your goal.

We'll revisit this idea of creating content along our story arc in the context of data and image slides in the upcoming chapters. Before we do that, let's look at another example of using words wisely.

Say it with words: TRIX case study

Recall that we closed Chapter 5 with my framework for the TRIX presentation. This will be the focus when I meet with the client group at Nosh to share the results of the market research our team has undertaken and our related recommendations. As a reminder, the structure I set in Chapter 5 is shown in Figure 6.11.

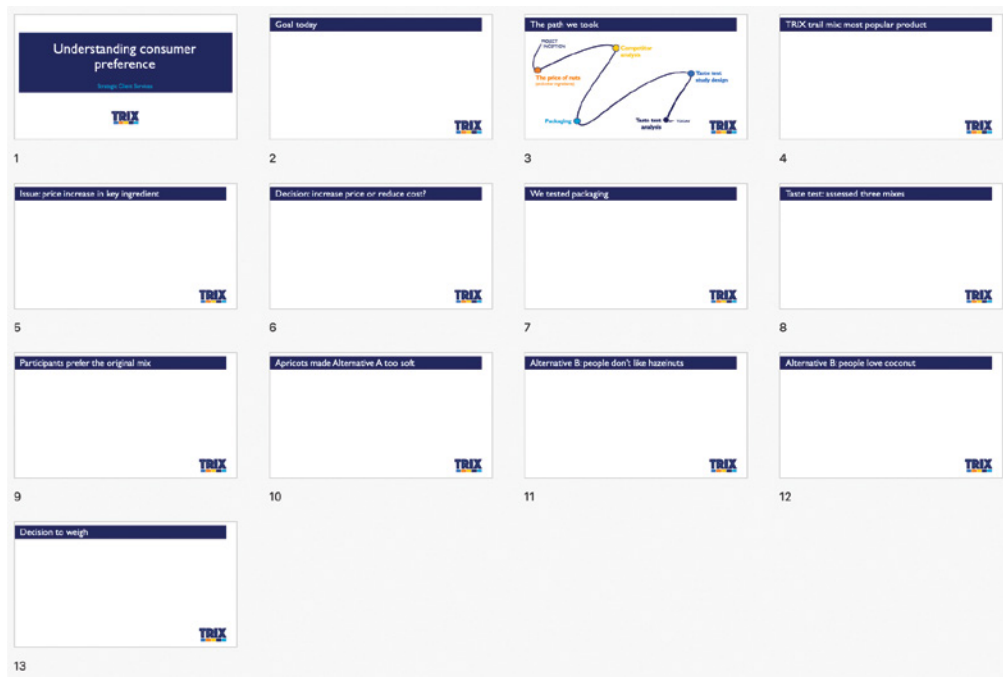


FIGURE 6.11 The presentation structure we set in Chapter 5

It's time to start filling in the content.

Just as we did at the onset of this chapter, let's start at the beginning of our slide deck with the presentation title. The placeholder title in Figure 6.11 is "Understanding consumer preference." This is fairly descriptive. What if, instead of merely introducing the topic and what I want to do (help them

understand consumer preferences), I give a glimpse of something of what we found? Perhaps I can use my title to get people's attention and introduce a sense of intrigue.

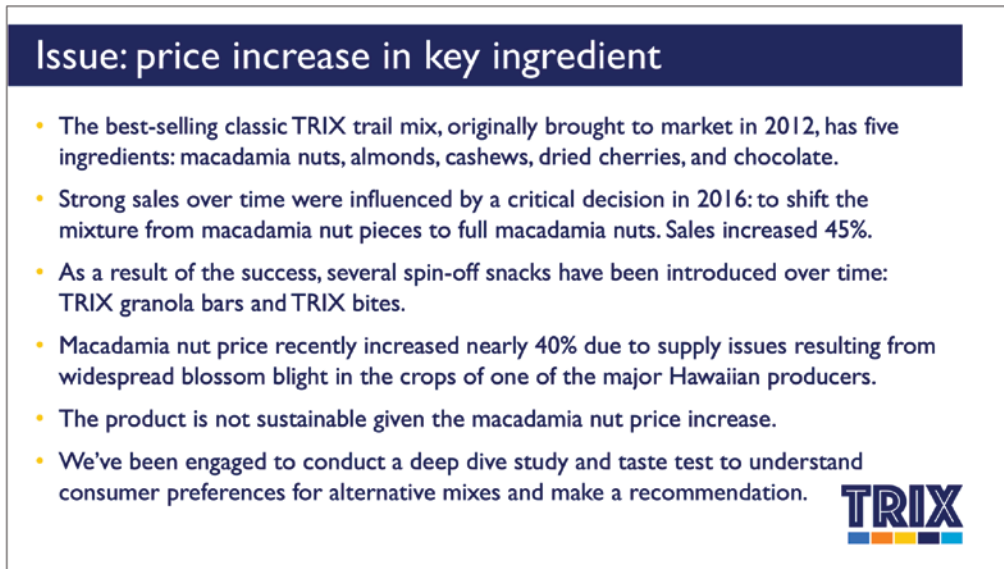
When it comes to exactly what I aim to communicate, I review the Big Idea from Chapter 2: *Consider an alternative trail mix blend that balances consumer preference with the desire to lower cost by decreasing macadamia nuts, adding coconut, and modifying the packaging so potential buyers can see the product.* We talked in this chapter about actually communicating the Big Idea as a slide. As another strategy, from my Big Idea I can create a pithy, repeatable phrase and then use that to title my presentation.

In this scenario, the crux of the matter centers around macadamia nuts. They are a key ingredient in the original mix, and it's their rising cost that was the impetus of this work in the first place. We found that consumers love them. Our recommendation is to keep this key ingredient, albeit in lower quantity, to balance consumer preference and cost. Taking this all into account, I transform my Big Idea into a simple statement: *the magic is in the macadamia nuts.* I will title my presentation with this.

I spend time on each of my slide titles to ensure they highlight the takeaway as I flesh out the individual content. Speaking of which, let's focus on one of the early planned slides where words will be the primary content.

We know from Chapter 1 that my audience is a mixed group who has different levels of familiarity with the background, how my team got involved, and the study and research we've undertaken. At the beginning of the presentation, I want to share context to get everyone on the same page and frame the overarching goal for the meeting.

To address this, I create the following slide.



Issue: price increase in key ingredient

- The best-selling classic TRIX trail mix, originally brought to market in 2012, has five ingredients: macadamia nuts, almonds, cashews, dried cherries, and chocolate.
- Strong sales over time were influenced by a critical decision in 2016: to shift the mixture from macadamia nut pieces to full macadamia nuts. Sales increased 45%.
- As a result of the success, several spin-off snacks have been introduced over time: TRIX granola bars and TRIX bites.
- Macadamia nut price recently increased nearly 40% due to supply issues resulting from widespread blossom blight in the crops of one of the major Hawaiian producers.
- The product is not sustainable given the macadamia nut price increase.
- We've been engaged to conduct a deep dive study and taste test to understand consumer preferences for alternative mixes and make a recommendation.

TRIX

FIGURE 6.12 A text-heavy slide

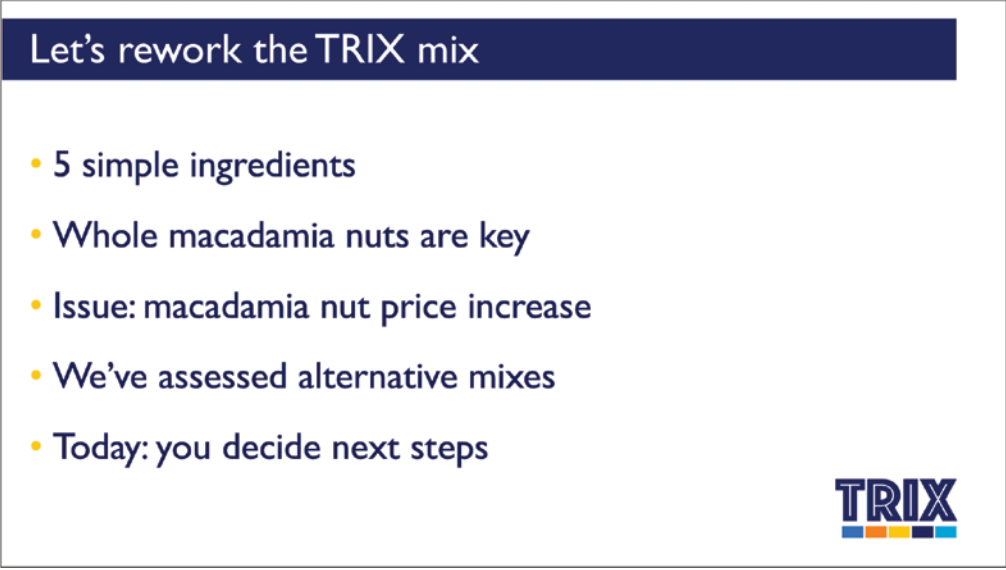
Review Figure 6.12 in light of the lessons we've just covered. Have I used words wisely?

I turn my attention first to the slide title. It calls out the issue of increasing price. This is a takeaway title, but is it the one I want here? Rather than orient people around the issue, perhaps I should direct them toward a potential solution.

When it comes to the text on the body of the slide, it does describe the context. Someone could read through this to get a good understanding of the plot of my story. However, I don't want my audience to do that. I will be there; I'll simply say these words. The slide that helps me do this should augment me as the presenter, not compete with or replace me.

With these ideas in mind, I transform this issue-focused teleprompter slide into something more. It centers on what we will accomplish together: rework the mix. I can still use text to remind myself of the upcoming content (and

reinforce it for others) but in a way that their attention will remain primarily on me through this process. See Figure 6.13.



Let's rework the TRIX mix

- 5 simple ingredients
- Whole macadamia nuts are key
- Issue: macadamia nut price increase
- We've assessed alternative mixes
- Today: you decide next steps

TRIX

FIGURE 6.13 Fewer, punchier bullets

Note how much easier and faster Figure 6.13 is to process than the text-heavy version. But I can take things a step further. I want to pause on each of these bullets to fully explain the ideas and weave them together as I lead people through this content. Rather than show them all at once, I'll introduce them one at a time. Then I will add relevant context through my spoken words. My audience won't be tempted to read ahead, because I won't give them the ability to do so. I'll achieve this through light animation in my slide application.

When I initially show this slide, it will be blank, save the title and logo. On my first click, the initial bullet will appear while I outline the five ingredients in the original TRIX mix. When I click again, the second bullet will appear, and

the formatting of the first bullet will change to transparent. Figure 6.14 shows what the slide will look like when I discuss the macadamia nut price increase (the third bullet point).



FIGURE 6.14 Animate progression to make current focus clear

I will continue in this manner through each of the points, pausing to lend additional context through my voiceover as I go. My audience can see when they turn their attention from me to the slide, both at what point we are currently and the path we've taken to get there.

This is an example of rethinking how we use our words in a presentation setting—designing the text on our slide to work with us instead of against us. Take a look at the before and after.

Issue: price increase in key ingredient	Let's rework the TRIX mix
• The best-selling classic TRIX trail mix, originally brought to market in 2012, has five ingredients: macadamia nuts, almonds, cashews, dried cherries, and chocolate. • Strong sales over time were influenced by a critical decision in 2016: to shift the mixture from macadamia nut pieces to full macadamia nuts. Sales increased 45%. • As a result of the success, several spin-off snacks have been introduced over time: TRIX granola bars and TRIX bites. • Macadamia nut price recently increased nearly 40% due to supply issues resulting from widespread blossom blight in the crops of one of the major Hawaiian producers. • The product is not sustainable given the macadamia nut price increase. • We've been engaged to conduct a deep dive study and taste test to understand consumer preferences for alternative mixes and make a recommendation.	• 5 simple ingredients • Whole macadamia nuts are key • Issue: macadamia nut price increase • We've assessed alternative mixes • Today: you decide next steps

FIGURE 6.15 Transition from teleprompter slide to using words wisely

This isn't the last you'll see of this content. We'll look at strategies for transitioning text to more visual content in Chapter 8. Before we do that, let's examine another scenario where words play a critical role: in our communication of data.



show data in graphs

We use data to inform, build credibility, support ideas, battle false preconceptions, help people understand something in a new way, and drive change. Executed well, a graph brings an awesome “aha” moment of understanding, turning data into information that can be used to make a smarter decision, have a more robust conversation, or act with greater confidence.

Before we get into how exactly to do that, I have one important caveat: just because you have data *doesn't* necessitate its inclusion in your presentation. When integrating numbers and graphs into a communication, step back and ask yourself why precisely you are doing so. What will the given data point or graph achieve? This practice will help the data you incorporate be more effective. Also, when you clearly know the reason for communicating specific data, it is easier to create data visualizations that accomplish what you intend. We'll discuss practical ways to do this over the course of this chapter.

For more on data visualization, read my first book

For a foundational review of communicating effectively with data, check out my first book, *storytelling with data: a data visualization guide for business professionals*. You'll encounter some concepts that will be familiar from your reading here (in particular, the importance of audience, message, and story), plus greater depth on communicating with graphs in particular. This includes thorough discussion of common business visualizations, graph design considerations, and many illustrative examples. The follow-up, *storytelling with data: let's practice!*, shares additional case studies and strategies through a plethora of exercises, inviting you to take a hands-on approach and hone your data communication skills via guided practice.

You do not need an advanced quantitative degree to make a good graph. You also don't have to use fancy graph types or special tools to communicate effectively with data. It is helpful to possess an understanding of some visual design concepts specific to graphs, which we'll develop in this chapter. Before we do that, let's talk a little more about typical goals for visualizing data in general and in a business setting in particular.

Why we visualize data

I characterize data visualization as turning numbers (data) into pictures (graphs). We graph data to answer a question, create beauty, entertain, evoke feelings, experiment, explain, explore, grab attention, influence, inspire, make someone laugh, or aid understanding. This is not a comprehensive list of motives, by the way—there is a spectrum of reasons that drive people to visualize data.

When I graph data, it is most often in a business setting. My main objectives are typically to create understanding and drive others toward a specific action.

I use graphs for speed, comprehension, and memorability. Our visual system is fast at processing information (faster than our verbal system, which means an effective picture or graph has the potential to get an idea across more quickly than written text, a concept we'll discuss further in Chapter 8). A good graph also facilitates the explanation of something more complex, particularly when it's useful for people to be able to see something in order to understand it better. Finally, visual recall is something we can use when we display data in graphs. When I make a statement and show a graph that illustrates it, not only is my audience able to remember what I said but also what they saw.

Given these goals, I actively simplify my data visualizations. This generally means showing my audience where to look, what to see, and how each piece fits into the broader picture. While these are things we should aim to do with any content we create to communicate to others, there's a process I follow for graphs specifically: articulate the takeaway in words, iterate on the visual form to select a graph that will help me bring those words to life, refine the graph, and finally, weave that graph into the overarching story. Let's talk more about each of these steps.

Articulate: put your point into words

What do you want someone else to see when they look at your graph? You already know the answer to this question—it is why you've chosen to include the data in the first place. We've seen the benefits of iterating to refine the words we use in the context of our overarching message and the way we title our presentations and slides. This practice can be applied to our graphs, too.

Articulating observations for yourself about the data you plan to show will help you make better graphs. I'm a fan of a simple exercise to do this. For any graph that you plan to include in your presentation, form a few sentences about it. Determine which is the most important and improve it. This sentence should describe the specific takeaway that you want people to know. In other words, if someone looked at your graph and asked you the question, "So what?," your sentence should answer this. Don't just do this activity in your head: write it down. Often, the initial sentence formed is longer or more

complicated than it needs to be. Edit your sentence. Say it out loud. Make it as simple as possible.

Shouldn't the data speak for itself?

The instruction to put data into words runs counter to the misguided notion that data speaks for itself. Sure, a graph can speak for itself, but without our help, it runs the risk of saying something different to each person who looks at it!

When you are the person who is communicating data, you are in a singular position to help others derive greater value from that data. You likely know it better than anyone else. It is your job to convey that understanding and the viewpoint you have developed based on it. Don't ask your audience to undertake this work. Note that this doesn't mean others will necessarily agree with you, but it sets the best stage for understanding and a productive conversation. Put your data into words!

If there are a number of observations that are important, it's possible that you'll end up with multiple sentences. Undertake this process as many times as needed to ensure the sentence outlining each individual takeaway is concise. (More than one sentence often means you'll have various iterations of your graph on your data slides to walk through these nuances—an approach we'll look at soon.)

The graph you use to form your sentence doesn't have to be perfect. It can be rough, may have some clutter, or not be the ideal graph form. That's okay. The words you choose to describe it are going to help you refine it. It's an iterative process. The more time you spend with the graph or iterating through various

potential views, the better you'll understand the data. Use this increased understanding to continue to enhance the words you use to describe it, then use those words to further improve the graph.

Let's look at an example. Spend a moment studying Figure 7.1. What observations do you make? How would you put those into words—what sentences would you form about this graph to answer the question, "So what?"

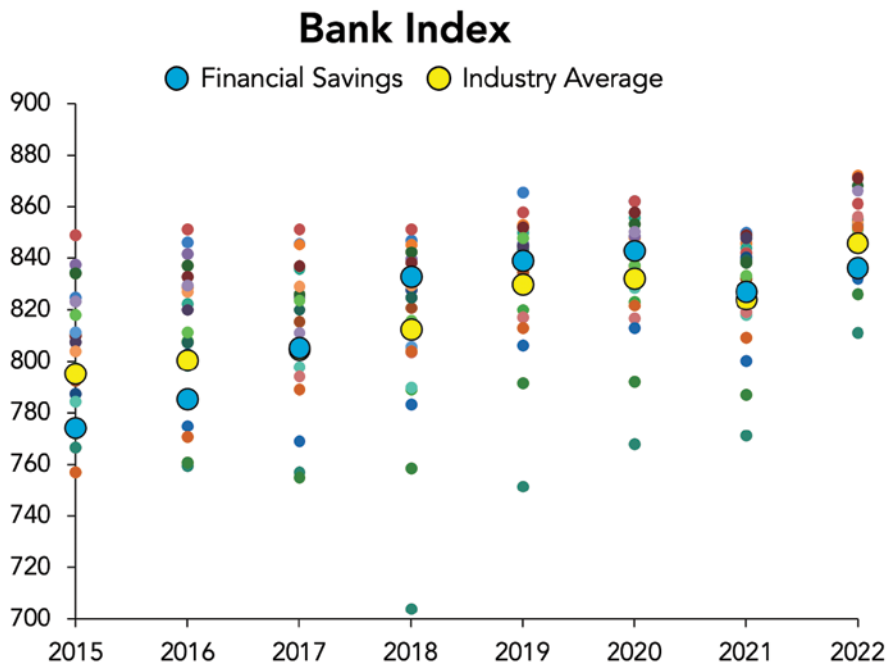


FIGURE 7.1 Study this graph

If you're struggling, fret not—this one is challenging. To further complicate matters, I haven't provided any context, so it's not surprising if you have more questions than observations at this point. Check out what happens, however, when I start formulating statements about the graph. Doing this forces me to explicitly call out some of the tacit knowledge I have due to my familiarity with the data that you do not. There are a number of observations I could articulate. As you

read through the following, refer back to Figure 7.1. Determine whether you see what I describe.

- There is variance in customer satisfaction across banks and over time.
- Satisfaction has generally increased across the industry, and the range from low to high is smaller in 2022 than in prior years.
- The industry average satisfaction is higher than Financial Savings in 2015–2016, at or below Financial Savings in 2017–2021, and then higher again in 2022.

Let's presume that Financial Savings is my client, and this final sentence is the main takeaway I want to convey to them. It's time to refine it. I could simplify it and make Financial Savings the focal point with something like, "Financial Savings is below the industry average for the first time in five years." I would be better off saying those words than communicating the visual in its current form. Rather than throw out the graph, however, let's use the clarity of what we want to communicate to improve it.

Visualize: let form follow function

You may be familiar with the adage "form follows function." Suppose that you are designing a chair. This idea dictates that you would start by determining what function you want the chair to perform. Is it a desk chair that should promote good posture in an office or a lounge chair to relax in the sun? Obviously, these two uses will drive different designs. The same is true for our graphs. When we start by outlining the specific function we want a given graph to serve, it makes the process of choosing an effective one much easier.

Whether a data novice or an expert data wrangler, people often unintentionally overcomplicate the function they expect their graph to perform, which in turn convolutes its form. For those who haven't worked much with data, making a graph can feel intimidating, like it has to answer every possible question

that could arise. Those who work with data regularly might feel that visualizing it is an opportunity to showcase all the complicated work that took place or to demonstrate prowess in their tools.

These perceived constraints lead people to design a table of data that is overwhelming, a busy graph that is difficult to understand, a visual that is comprehensible only to those involved in the technical analysis or with an advanced quantitative degree, or other issues. Because the function we expect the graph to perform has been overcomplicated, it's not surprising that the form that follows is unnecessarily intricate as well.

This is why we put our takeaway into words as the first step for making an effective graph. When we do that, it's easier to be explicit and specific about the highest priority function we need our graph to perform. When visualizing data in a business setting, there are a handful of graphs that handle common tasks:

- **Show a trend over time:** line graph, slopegraph, area chart
- **Compare across categories:** bar chart (vertical, horizontal, stacked, diverging), dot plot
- **Express a relationship:** scatterplot, waterfall chart, pie chart

There are numerous existing resources on these and additional graphs. Instead of repeating that here, let's revisit the example from the last section and see how we can visualize the data to illuminate the point we want to make.

Tip: focus first on line graphs and bar charts

Whether you've been visualizing data for years or are building your very first graph, when communicating data to others, you will be best served by getting really good at making effective line graphs and bar charts before spending time expanding your graphical lexicon and visualization skills beyond these basics. Lines and bars are common—for good reason. Their broad familiarity renders them straightforward to interpret. There are some twists on these basics and also use cases for other visuals, though those will be rarer.

When you use a less common graph, you introduce a hurdle: you have to keep your audience's attention while you explain how to interpret the graph before you even start to talk about the data and what it shows. There will be instances when this makes sense—when the additional time and effort will be worthwhile because it allows you to highlight or explain something that is otherwise difficult to see or when organizational familiarity with a less common visual has been built over time—but those are exceptions, not the norm. In general, when communicating with data, keep things as simple as possible. This often means sticking with the basics: line graphs and bar charts.

You'll find many more examples of lines and bars in my other books. For a deeper exploration of additional common visuals, check out the SWD chart guide at storytellingwithdata.com/chart-guide. To further expand your graphicacy and see use cases for a wide variety of visuals, I recommend the book *Better Data Visualizations* by Jonathan Schwabish (Columbia University Press, 2021).

Recall that I articulated the key takeaway as “Financial Savings is below the industry average for the first time in five years.” This means when it comes to the function, it will be important to show industry and Financial Savings’ satisfaction over time. Let’s look at this data in a line graph. See Figure 7.2.

BRANCH SATISFACTION

Financial Savings is below industry for the first time in 5 years

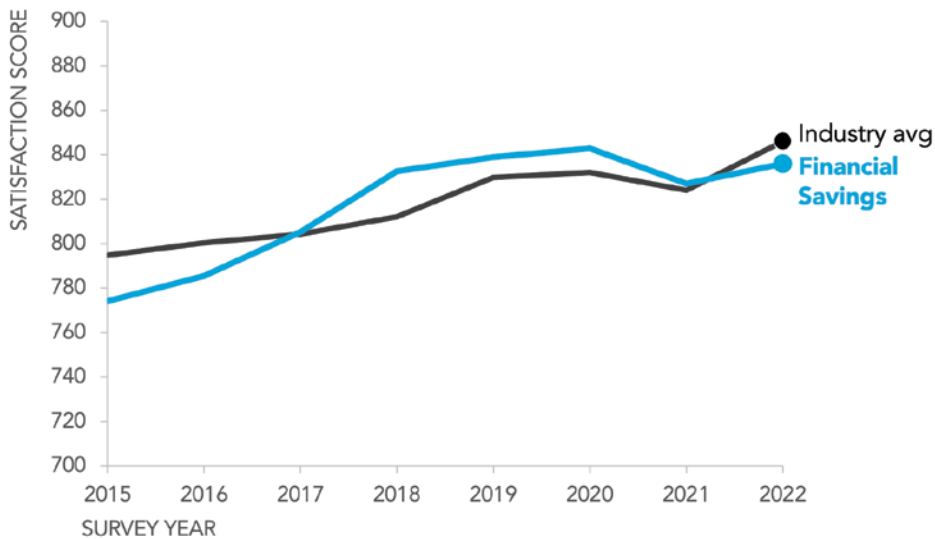


FIGURE 7.2 Form follows function

Choosing a graph form that works for the point is merely one consideration. To create the magic that allows an idea to come to life through a graph, take steps to make the process easy and enjoyable for your audience. This means identifying aspects that will feel like work to others and alleviating that effort to the extent possible through your graph design.

Figure 7.2 incorporates a number of improvements relative to Figure 7.1 that can be expanded to some general good practices for communicating with graphs. Each of these has to do with words and how we use them together with our graph to make things easy to understand.

- **Put the key takeaway into words.** Once you've articulated your key idea for yourself, integrate it into your graph to make the takeaway clear to others. Words have an amazing ability to prime. When you say something or write words about a graph, it sets expectations for what others should look for or see. Further, studies have shown that if you title a graph with the relevant message you'd like your audience to remember, they are more likely to remember it. Powerful stuff!
- **Include axis titles.** You know what is being plotted, so it seems obvious to you; this will not be the case for most others who encounter your graph. Take the simple step to include axis titles (in Figure 7.2, this is Satisfaction Score on the y-axis and Survey Year on the x-axis), so others are able to easily understand the data. I am an advocate of aligning graph and axis titles at the upper left to create visual structure. It's for the same reason that I often use all caps for axis titles: they have a clean rectangular shape compared to mixed case, which frames my graph nicely.
- **Label the data directly.** Rather than have a separate legend, when possible label data directly. See the placement of the Industry avg and Financial Savings labels to the right of the lines in Figure 7.2. This eliminates the labor of going back and forth between the legend and the data to decipher the graph.

I have also improved the graph by creating visual hierarchy, eliminating distractions and focusing attention on what remains. We'll talk more about that next.

Unsure which graph works?

Sketch or iterate in your tool and get feedback

Much in the same way we found benefit in beginning presentation planning in a low-tech fashion, making a good graph can start with pen and paper, too. Particularly in cases where you aren't sure which visual works best or believe a less common view may be worth the tradeoffs, sketching to brainstorm and get a glimpse of how things could work is useful. When drawing, you don't form attachment to what you create like you do when you build in your spreadsheet or presentation application. This makes the iteration process faster due to the relative ease of letting go of less desirable options.

Data drawings are also a great point at which to get directional input from others. When concepts are rough, it's easier to assess the overall form and function rather than get caught up in individual design considerations. Additionally, drawing frees you from tool constraints. Get things right on paper, then figure out what tools or experts can help you realize your ideas. Remain open to making changes. Often, when we conceptualize on paper, we aren't precisely plotting every data point. Continue to evaluate the effectiveness of your chosen route and modify as needed.

You can also iterate through different views of data in your graphing application. Let it be a quick and dirty process—the graphs don't have to be polished at this point. Create a few different ones and determine which will help you best make your point. If you are still uncertain, solicit input from others.

Refine the graph: declutter and focus

We touched on visual hierarchy in Chapter 6 in our discussion about communicating with text. By de-emphasizing or removing less critical components and selectively highlighting the important aspects, we make it easier for our audience to process the information we communicate. When I'm refining my visuals in this manner, I typically start by identifying and eliminating clutter.

Declutter your graphs

Let's explore the power of decluttering through an example. Imagine you work for a company that conducts an annual corporate fundraiser. Monetary donations and food donations are brought together to prepare meals to feed those in need in the community in which your organization operates. You track a simple metric over time: the number of meals served per year. The initial graph you create to visualize this data might look something like Figure 7.3.

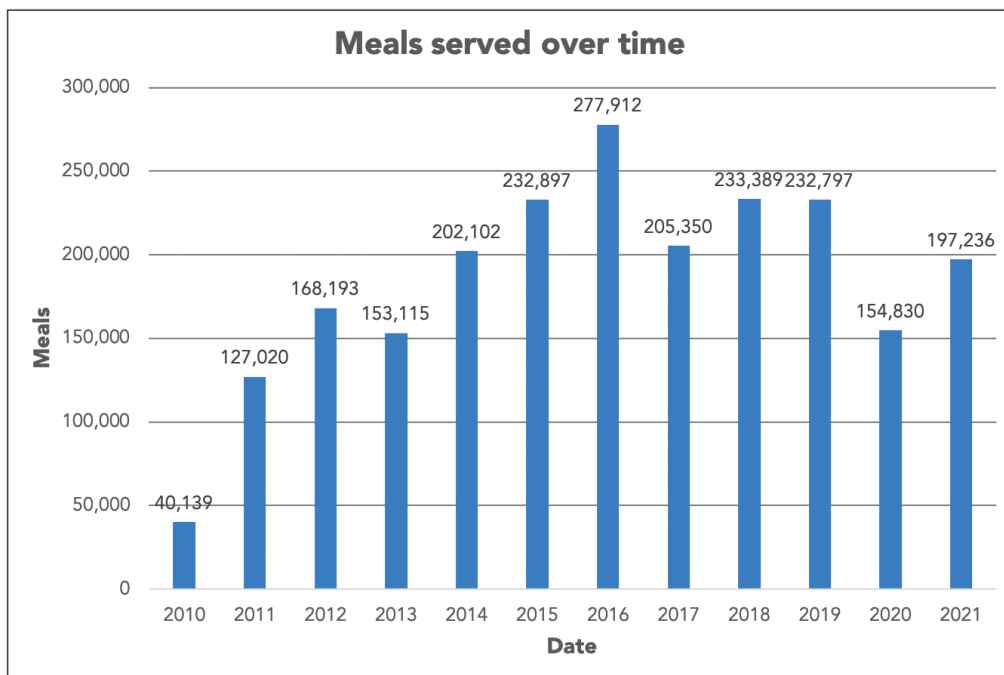


FIGURE 7.3 Initial graph

Figure 7.3—like all of the graphs in this book—was created in Microsoft PowerPoint. (An identical version could be created using Excel, which historically has been my primary graphing tool; I’ve transitioned to making graphs for presentations directly in PowerPoint to save the step of copying and pasting from Excel.) Because the default settings of any tool have been modified to address many different scenarios, there will almost always be details you can tailor to better accommodate your specific situation.

If you work with a different application for visualizing data, I encourage you to create a basic graph and undertake the process that follows.

Before proceeding to learn what changes I make to declutter this visual, spend a few moments considering Figure 7.3. How does this graph feel to you? In an effort to simplify, which elements are you inclined to deemphasize, eliminate, or modify in other ways?

Download files and access additional resources

You can download the slides shown throughout this book at storytelling-withyou.com/downloads. If you’re curious about how particular design components were built, I encourage you to explore these files. Additionally, you’ll find many resources specific to graphs, including tutorials, on the *storytelling with data* blog (storytellingwithdata.com/blog) and YouTube channel (storytellingwithdata.com/youtube). For ways to practice graphing and telling stories with data and exchange feedback with other members, I invite you to join our online community (storytellingwithdata.com/community).

To me, the graph in Figure 7.3 feels messy. While this version would be totally fine to use behind the scenes to get a better understanding of the data or in a casual conversation with a colleague, it is not something I recommend presenting in a formal setting. This would be lazy because there are quick and easy things we can do to make it easier for our audience.

Figure 7.4 shows my decluttered version of the graph.

Meals served over time

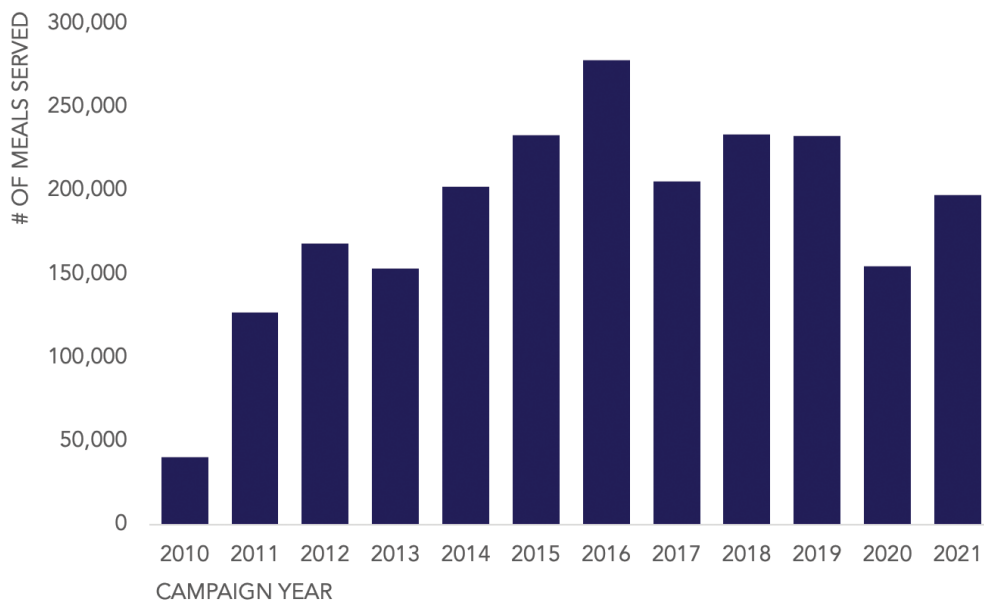


FIGURE 7.4 Decluttered graph

I made a number of changes, which you can identify by comparing the versions. Below, I'll outline common forms of clutter to remove when refining a graph.

- **Graph borders:** These are usually unnecessary. Instead, use white space to set your graph apart from other elements on the page or screen.

- **Gridlines:** Eliminating the horizontal or vertical lines that cross your graph is a simple step that makes the data stand out more. If specific numerical values are important, label the data directly (after doing this, sometimes it will make sense to get rid of the axis altogether).
- **Axis lines:** You won't *always* do away with the x- and y-axis lines (at minimum, you may push them to the background by making them gray); they lend visual structure to graphs. However, there are instances where you can remove them without losing anything (the same goes for tick marks, the small demarcation lines on an axis line—assess on a case-by-case basis).
- **Trailing zeros:** If every number on your axis has zeros past the decimal place, round to the nearest whole number. For large numbers with many zeros, think about whether scaling to hundreds, thousands, or millions will make the information easier to digest and discuss. (I opted not to do this in the previous example because thousands has always seemed like an awkward unit to me, but you may feel differently, and that is fine.)
- **Data markers:** These shapes (often on line graphs) are usually not necessary on every data point. Used sparingly, they can help direct attention.
- **Data labels:** Only include the numerical labels that specify the value when you have a clear reason for doing so. Often, even when you opt to include data labels, you don't need them on every single data point (in bar graphs with sufficient space, I recommend embedding labels in the interior of the bars to combine the elements visually and decrease perceived clutter).
- **Diagonal text:** This looks messy, grabs attention, and is slower to read. Aim for horizontal text when possible (if you have a bar chart with long category names, try changing the layout from vertical to horizontal to orient the text in a likewise manner).
- **Center-aligned text:** Such text is often floating in space, and when it flows onto multiple lines, it looks sloppy due to the jagged edges. I'm a fan of left- or right-justified text that is aligned with other elements to create visual order.

- **Unnecessary color:** More than a couple colors in a graph make it difficult to concentrate and can cause unnecessary work for others. Sparing color is an excellent tool to focus people's attention, an idea we'll revisit soon.

Note that there will be exceptions. Always evaluate the specific scenario in which you are communicating and what will work best given the data, the audience, and your time and tool constraints. If you're able to explain why you've elected to include items or done something in a way that runs counter to the tips in the preceding list, odds are you've put enough thought into it to make that a reasonable choice.

Is a little clutter in your visual communication going to be the end of the world? Probably not. Each individual piece of clutter on its own is relatively minor. However, when there are many unnecessary elements, they add up to create a less-than-ideal experience, distracting attention from our data and our message.

Good graph design: it's the little things

In our conversation about clutter, I've framed it mainly in terms of extra stuff to eliminate. Another way to think about making an effective data visualization is to start with a blank slate and build it piece by piece and with a critical eye on each element you add. There are many little decisions we make every time we graph data—some explicitly through our design choices and others implicitly when we don't modify our tool's default settings. Constructing a graph one element at a time forces you to contemplate each decision and its impact on the visual. Watch me do this in the video *it's the little things: ten tiny considerations when designing a graph* (storytellingwithyou.com/littlethings).

After taking the time to declutter your data visualization, also spend time intentionally directing attention to add value in its place.

Focus attention

When you make a graph or a slide, you are familiar with it. You know where to look and what to see. For this to be as obvious to others, we must take intentional steps in our design. We've already seen how words help us make our point clear. Pair this with sparing contrast to indicate where to look, and you have a potent combination. Let's review another example of this strategy, and then I'll outline a variety of methods to focus attention.

Did Figure 7.4 leave you dissatisfied or with a feeling that it was unfinished? It was. Making it clear where to look can't be achieved by simply eliminating clutter; we also need to intentionally direct attention within the content that remains. Let's assume that the primary message we want to highlight is that the number of meals served has increased since the dip in 2020 (due largely to the COVID pandemic) but has stayed lower than other recent years.

Figure 7.5 shows one way to achieve this.

Meals served over time: up slightly in 2021

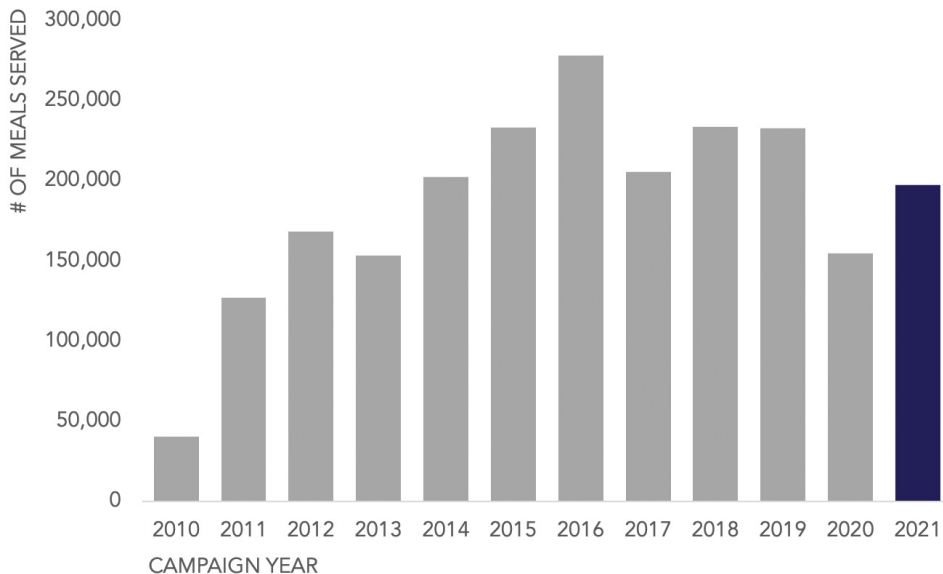


FIGURE 7.5 Focused graph

I chose to de-emphasize meals served from 2010–2020 by making them gray. They are there for context, but the navy bar at the right (this color was chosen to align with the branding of the organization) calls for the audience’s attention. When you make it clear where to look and what to see, this helps overcome potential issues. Even if it’s not the perfect chart choice or some clutter is present, your graph can still be effective.

To achieve this focus, contrast is key. Below, I’ve listed some common ways to create visual contrast within a graph.

- **Color:** Use a bold, bright color to emphasize a specific data series or data point. This works especially well when the rest of the graph is black, gray, or otherwise muted, as illustrated in Figure 7.5.
- **Intensity:** Render the focal point(s) in full intensity and push the rest visually back by making them less intense. A brute-force way to achieve this (that is particularly useful if you don’t have the ability to make formatting changes to your graph) is to cover less critical components with a semi-transparent shape.
- **Thickness:** In a line graph, make the primary data series you want people to look at thicker, the others thinner, or combine these two approaches. You can similarly use thickness with important text (e.g. titles, labels, annotations) by making it boldface.
- **Size:** Relative size visually indicates relative importance. If something is important, it may make sense to make it larger than other features in the overall design.
- **Added elements:** In some cases, pointing an arrow at, circling, or otherwise enclosing pieces of interest can be effective (still, there are often more eloquent ways to highlight through how you design the graph). Some items that add information in addition to signaling importance include sparing data markers and labels or annotation.

- **Animation:** Motion captures attention. The simple act of a data point not being present and then appearing will steer eyes in the right direction. This is particularly useful in live presentations, and we'll look at examples of this soon.

This isn't a comprehensive list of ways to direct attention, but it is a good start and hopefully gets you thinking critically about how to prompt others to look where you'd like them to in your graphs and other visuals. It may also make sense to layer various elements of visual contrast. If I want you to look at a given bar in a bar graph, I could render it in a different color, add the data label to the bar, and bold the data label text. To achieve clear focus, contrast should be sparing—if you make everything different, nothing stands out!

Study shows benefits of focusing attention in data viz

Is there a study that proves this stuff works? That's a question I've received about decluttering and directing attention in data visualization more than once. While I have plenty of observational evidence, it's only as of 2021 that there is a prominent study to cite as well.

I partnered with the Visual Thinking Lab at Northwestern University on research summarized in the paper titled "Decluttering and Focus: Empirically Evaluating Design Guidelines for Effective Data Communication" (by Ajani, K. et al.). Participants were shown a mix of 1) cluttered, 2) decluttered, and 3) decluttered *and* focused data visualizations. They were asked to evaluate the designs on aesthetics, clarity, professionalism, and trustworthiness and also to redraw and recall topics and conclusions of the previously seen visuals.

While decluttering the designs led to higher ratings on professionalism, adding focus to the design led to higher ratings on aesthetics and clarity and improved memory and recall. Bottom line: there is measurable benefit to focusing your audience's attention.

The examples we've looked at in this chapter have been single snapshots of data to illustrate common practices for making a good graph. Once you've done so—taken steps to make it clear to people where to look and what to see—it's time to incorporate that effective graph into the overall story.

Weave graphs into your story

You may recall that in Chapter 6 we discussed using word slides along the path of our story, following the narrative arc introduced in Chapter 4. We started at the beginning of the story with plot slides to set the context; the story continues via mid-story slides and then ends with closing slides. While there will always be exceptions, I find that the majority of data slides presented in a business setting fit best in the *mid-story* section of the overall path. This is because there is often situational context that must be detailed before jumping into the data. By the closing of the presentation, we've typically moved past the data into the more actionable realm of what to do in light of the improved understanding we've helped facilitate.

Successfully presenting data involves more than simply showing a well-designed graph. Have you ever been in a meeting or presentation where a graph is put on the big screen and you're so busy trying to decipher it that you've stopped listening to the person speaking? This happens frequently. Rather than create data slides that distract, aim to build slides that work seamlessly with the spoken words of your presentation, reinforcing the points you make and the story you tell.

We can do this by designing slides that set the stage for our data and then building and progressing through a given graph. In the meals-served scenario that we've looked at several times in this chapter—after setting the general context or plot but before showing any data—I could incorporate a slide like the following.



FIGURE 7.6 Mostly blank slide to set the stage

Figure 7.6 is a blank slide, save the slide title. That is by design. This will remind me when I'm presenting to set up what will come next (which can either follow on the next slide or be animated to appear on this one). Thinking ahead to my presentation, on this slide I will say something like, "Back in 2010, we launched an exciting new program with the goal of feeding those in need in our community. I'm going to show you just how many meals we've served over time."

Because my audience won't have anything to distract them after they quickly scan the title, I'll have their full attention when I set the context. This helps ease the transition into the graph.

In the same way that we animated small sections of text to appear on our word slides in Chapter 6, I will build my graph in steps as I explain it. After setting up what I'm going to show, I *could* simply introduce the bar chart from Figure 7.5. I might do that if the history was well known by others, and I only wanted to focus on the recent year relative to the rest. However, in the event that I want to walk others through the data and lend insight to explain what has driven

the ups and downs over time, this wouldn't be a smart approach. If I show all the data immediately, it's too easy for people to look at it and then direct their attention elsewhere altogether or at a different point in the graph. We can ease the latter through selective highlighting, but if you'd like your audience to accompany you as you tell the story of your data, set up your graph first. Then progress through the data step by step, revealing only what you want them to see while you verbally make the relevant points.

While this strategy can be used for a simple graph—which we'll see momentarily—it is *especially* useful when communicating something dense or unfamiliar. Introducing and discussing one or a couple of components at a time allows you to build to a complex visual that doesn't feel complicated. We'll look at an instance of this when we return to the case study later in this chapter.

Back to meals served over time: after my set-up slide where I seeded the expectation for what's to come, I'll introduce the first iteration of the graph. See Figure 7.7.

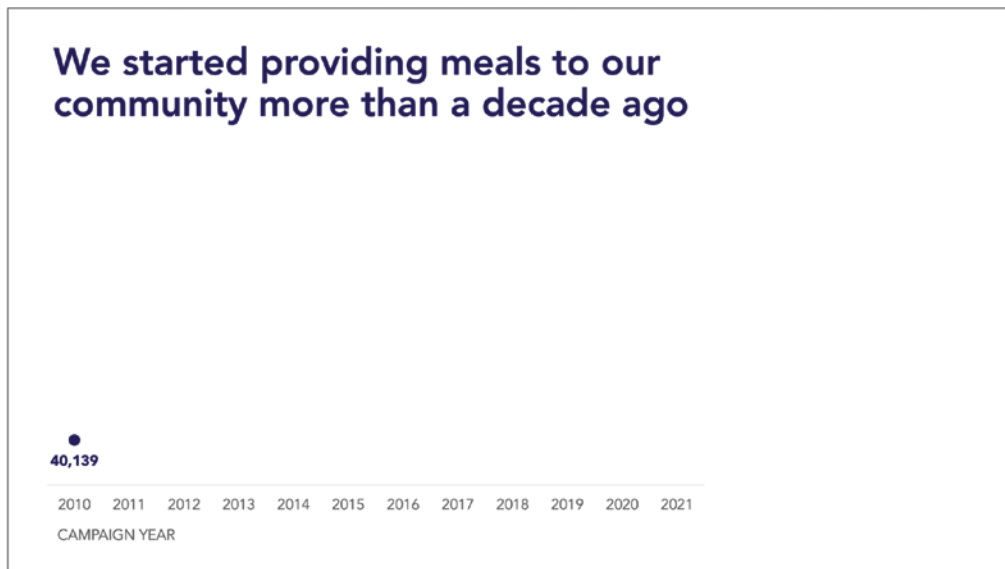


FIGURE 7.7 Start to build the graph

As I put up this slide, I will say, “On the vertical y-axis, I’ll be plotting the number of meals served. Back in 2010, we launched the pilot program. We served *over forty thousand* meals that first year, markedly more than our twenty-five thousand goal.” To tell the story of meals served over time, I will start with this single data point and then build a line graph (instead of the bar chart that we looked at previously for this data). This will make it easier for people to see the increase or decrease from year to year through the relative slopes of the lines that connect the data points. I’ve also stripped away some of the graph details (graph title, y-axis title, and y-axis labels). I will share these particulars through my spoken words. (If I were sending these slides out to be consumed on their own or was worried this might confuse, I would retain them for clarity.)

My subsequent slide could look like Figure 7.8.



FIGURE 7.8 Continue building the graph

I would present Figure 7.8 with the accompanying voiceover: “Given the wild success that first year, we decided to make it an annual campaign. As word spread, more and more colleagues got involved, including our executives, who made some sizable donations. We served one hundred and sixty-eight

thousand meals by the third year of the program.” Anticipate how I could continue to build the graph in this way, revealing only a year or two of data at a time to highlight specific points and lend additional context and information as necessary. Eventually, this would culminate in my final, complete graph.

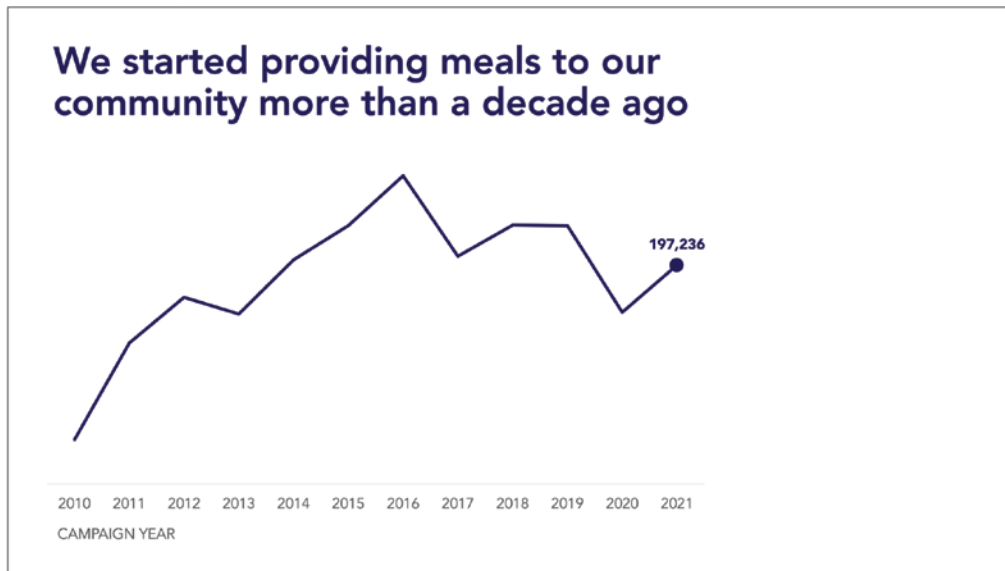


FIGURE 7.9 The complete graph

Upon progressing to the final graph in Figure 7.9, I’ll highlight the takeaway that we identified when we looked at this data initially in this chapter: “Meals served increased in 2021 relative to the COVID-dampened support in 2020; however, they remain below recent years.” I could then transition into the end of my story—my intended call to action or the discussion I wish to frame. Or, if this is a single piece of a more robust story, I would move from here into the next chapter of what I want to communicate.

Animate data for the virtual setting

This strategy of setting the stage and then building and progressing through a graph is particularly useful in a virtual environment. Many things compete for attention when your audience is sitting behind their computer—don't give them an excuse to tune out! Putting a complicated graph in front of them is an invitation to do exactly that. On the other hand, when you don't show them everything at once, it helps keep them focused. They won't want to miss the point of your graph. The simple visual motion of elements appearing helps maintain attention. Also, as we've discussed, others are more likely to actively listen to you because they aren't spending brainpower figuring out where to look or how to decipher—you are telling and showing them! You are leading them through the story of your data. That sounds much more pleasant for everyone than simply showing a graph, right?

When presenting data, you should almost always have only one graph per slide. This is for a number of reasons. It's hard to talk about multiple graphs simultaneously and easier to direct attention with fewer things on the screen. There is also a size consideration: multiple graphs on a single slide means the details are small. With a single graph, you have more space to make titles, labels, and the data itself large enough for everyone to see. The exception is when related graphs are so important to view together that you lose too much by breaking them up across multiple slides. Still, this can generally be addressed by making it clear how the different visuals connect.

When we build a single graph, as you saw in the previous example (Figures 7.7–7.9), it's pretty explicit how each one connects to the following. The audience literally sees how the data points relate as the line builds from left to right. There is benefit to doing this because the familiarity you've established means that later iterations of the graph will be faster for people to grasp and understand. Building on this idea of familiarity breeding comfort and efficiency,

starting from something known is a great strategy when you want to depart from the norm, too—an idea we’ll see employed soon in the case study.

Frequently, there are multiple different graphs that we want to communicate as part of our broader narrative. In some instances, there are still data points that we can highlight in one and then also in the next to make how they relate to each other obvious. More often, it’s our words and the framing of our presentation slides that will create this bridge for others. It’s the overarching story that will help make things clear.

This is one of the reasons that all of the planning we’ve done up to this point is vital. As we storyboarded, arranged our ideas along the narrative arc, and set the structure in our slideware, we thought about how the pieces were connected at each of these points. As you’re creating your data slides, you’ll want to refer back to this planning to make sure you incorporate transition slides, slide titles, and verbal segues that will make these connections straightforward for your audience.

Let’s revisit the case study. I’ll use it to reinforce a number of the lessons we’ve covered in this chapter and highlight how to connect different visuals as we build our data slides.

Show data in graphs: TRIX case study

You’ll recall that in Chapter 5 we set the structure for the presentation to our client team at Nosh. In Chapter 6, we framed the plot for the story we plan to present by creating word slides to support our communication of the general project context. Now, let’s determine how we can build slides with graphs to discuss the results of the taste test we conducted.

Figure 7.10 shows a summary of the data.

Taste Test Summary			
Measure	Original	Alternative A	Alternative B
Product Overall Liking	8.1*	7.2*	6.9*
Overall Appearance Liking	8.3*	6.8**	8.0**
Amount of Nuts JAR / Skew	89% JAR	67% JAR	71% JAR / 18% Too Much
Amount of Fruit JAR / Skew	80% JAR / 13% Not Enough	65% / 27% Too Much	89% JAR
Amount of Chocolate JAR / Skew	93% JAR	85% JAR	88% JAR
Overall Texture Liking	7.9**	6.9**	7.2*
Level of Crunchiness JAR / Skew	79% JAR	71% JAR / 20% Not Enough	85% JAR
Level of Chewiness JAR / Skew	83% JAR	67% / 31% Too Much	89% JAR
Overall Taste Liking	8.4*	7.4**	6.2**
Level of Saltiness JAR / Skew	89% JAR	77% JAR / 17% Not Enough	68% JAR / 27% Too Much
Level of Sweetness JAR / Skew	83% JAR	72% JAR / 19% Too Much	76% JAR / 14% Not Enough

N = 257 *Indicates significance at the 95% level. **Indicates significance at the 90% level.
 Liking: How much do you like or dislike the sample overall? JAR: Thinking of the sample you observed and consumed, what is your opinion of the [amount of or level of] [nuts / fruit / chocolate / crunchiness / chewiness / saltiness / sweetness]?



FIGURE 7.10 Summary table

Never present a slide like Figure 7.10 in a formal setting! This data dump is fine as the basis of a casual discussion with your colleagues in a working meeting or possibly in the appendix of your materials. It does not, however, meet the goal of communicating data when you have a specific story you want to tell.

The first thing I do is get clear about what I want to say and put specific takeaways into words. There are a number of different points of this data that I'll use throughout the presentation, but I won't show them all at once. I'll weave them into a connected narrative that helps it make sense to someone unfamiliar.

At this juncture, let's focus on a single takeaway to illustrate and apply the lessons we've learned. The original mix is preferred over the alternative trail mixes considered both overall and across the independent measures (appearance, texture, and taste). Figure 7.11 shows the initial bar graph I create with this data.

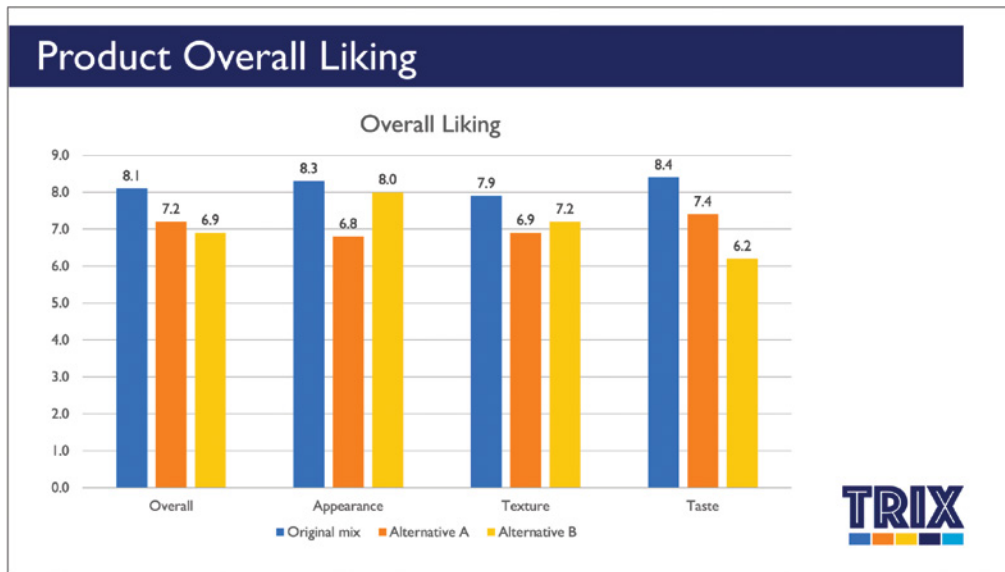


FIGURE 7.11 Initial graph

Next, I modify the visual to transition from a generic graph with default settings to one that is designed to meet my specific needs. I declutter, eliminating unnecessary elements so the data stands out more. I put my point into words and use contrast sparingly to indicate to my audience where to look for evidence of those words. See Figure 7.12.

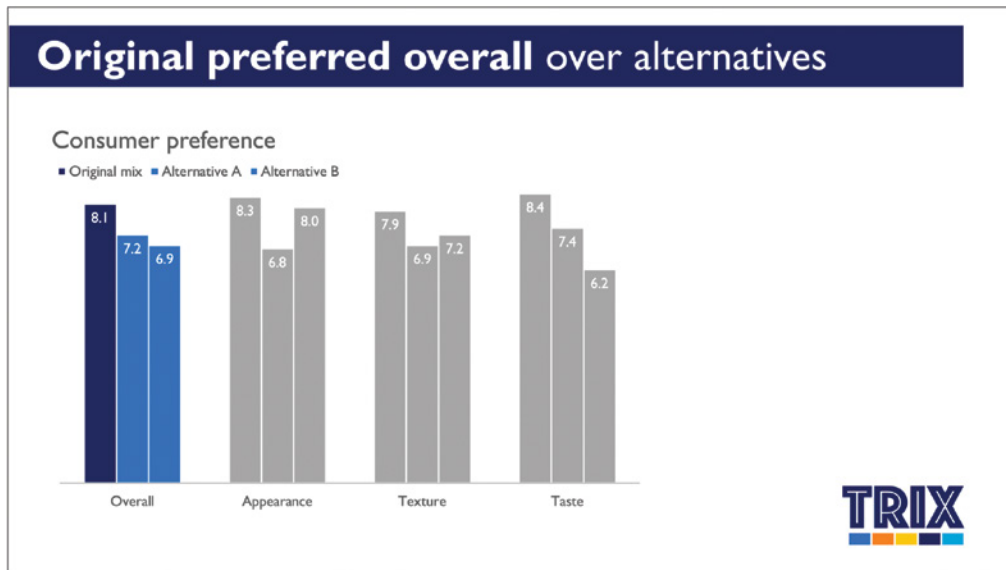


FIGURE 7.12 Redesigned slide shows where to look and what to see

Now is a good time to think about how I will lead people through this data. It's worth mentioning that the presentation structure I set in Chapter 5 (Figure 5.22) included a single slide to illustrate this point. I could simply use the bar chart from Figure 7.12 and be done—but I'd be doing everyone a disservice. As we discussed in this chapter, I don't simply want to show the graph. I want to weave data into my overarching story.

That single slide in the planned structure was only a placeholder. It's going to take more than one slide to accomplish my goals. I want to set the stage and build each graph to feel intuitive to my audience while maintaining their attention as I progress. I also want to connect the various views so everything fits together and makes sense.

As I step back and look at this data not on its own, but in light of everything I want to convey, I make a directional change. I recognize that I will want to show more data at once than is going to work well with the bar chart I initially designed. After realizing this and then brainstorming alternative approaches and discussing with colleagues, I decide that a more novel view will work better to show the high-level taste test data and connect it to the details I plan to communicate.

I start by highlighting that participants preferred the original mix and introduce the 9-point hedonic scale—which ranges from dislike extremely to like extremely—along which participants assessed the samples. See Figure 7.13.

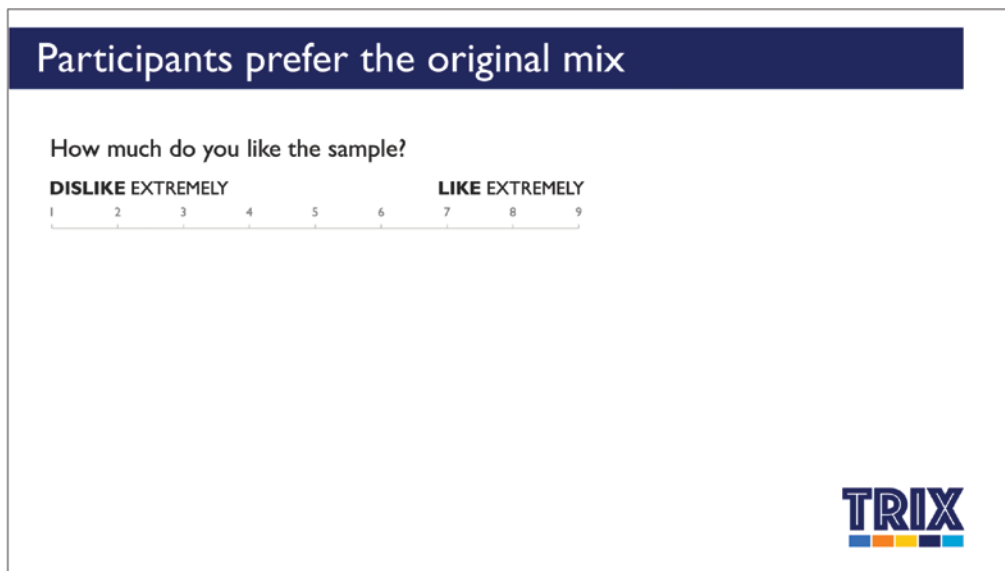


FIGURE 7.13 Set the stage

Then I layer data onto the graph so I can talk about each point. I start with the original mix, then add Alternatives A and B. Figure 7.14 shows what it looks like after these three pieces have been added.

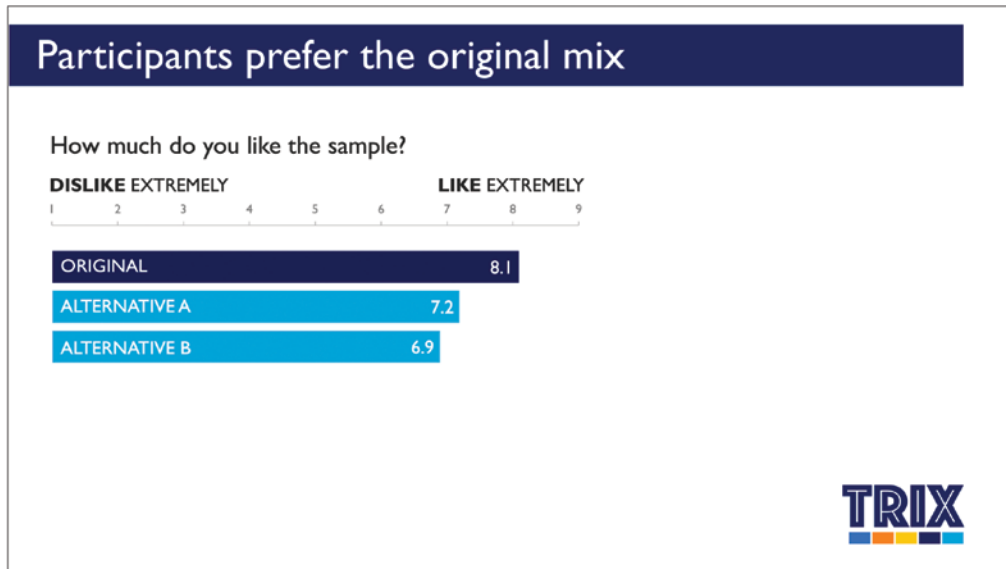


FIGURE 7.14 Build the graph

You'll notice that I'm plotting the data in a horizontal bar chart this time (rather than a vertical column chart with the liking scores on the y-axis that we saw previously in Figures 7.11 and 7.12). This is to set up the more novel approach I alluded to—a dot plot—but ensure the data is understood by connecting it to something commonly known (the bar chart). I begin by replacing the ends of the bars with circles. This works particularly well in a live setting, where the audience sees the circles replace the ends of the bars in the transition.

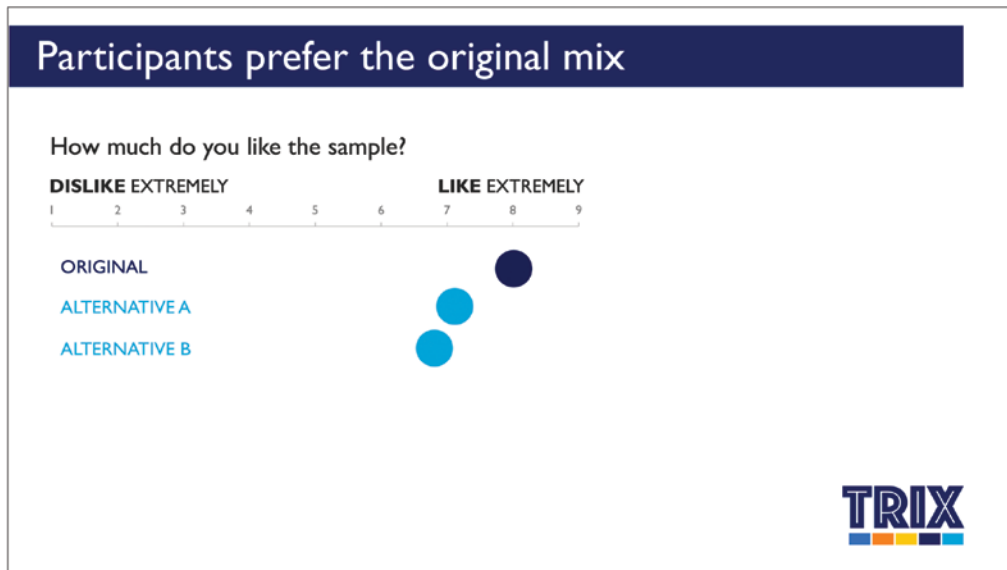


FIGURE 7.15 Transition to dot plot

Next, I collapse the dots onto a single line. This is another step to lead my audience through how to interpret the data.

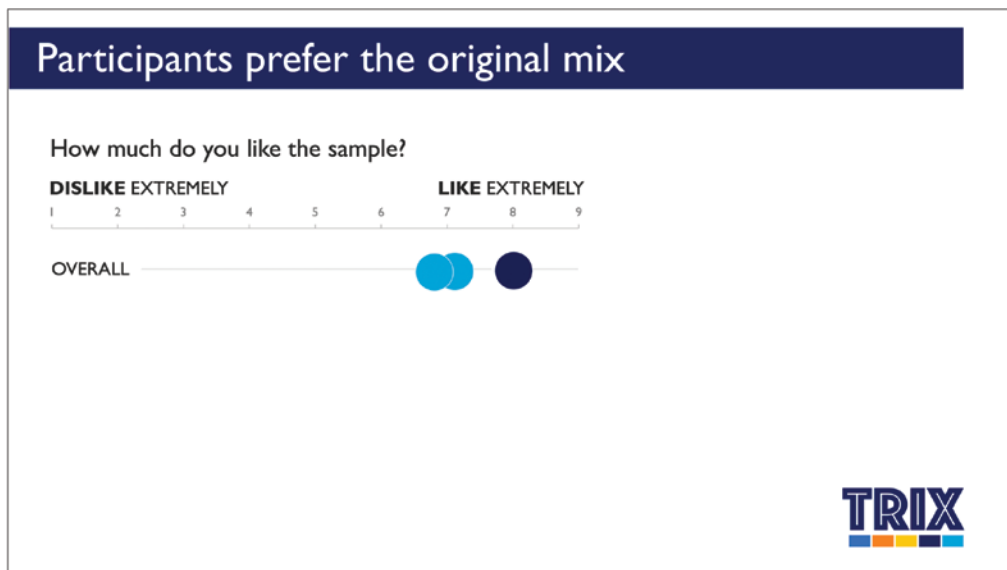


FIGURE 7.16 Collapse onto single line

After collapsing onto a single line, I have sufficient space to add the other dimensions from the taste test. Figure 7.17 shows what that looks like for the original mix.

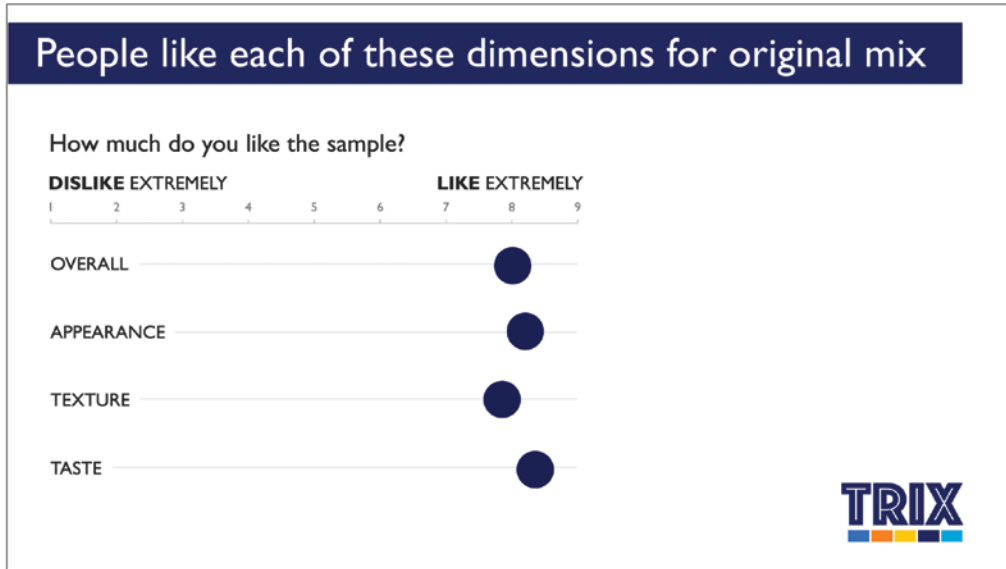


FIGURE 7.17 Layer on additional data

Now that I have the structure fully set up, I can layer on various data points and discuss them one or a few at a time (this is the part that would have been difficult with the bar chart I had originally planned that drove my decision to pivot to the dot plot).

I start with the original mix, as depicted in Figure 7.17. Then I layer on the liking scores for the alternatives tested. Figure 7.18 shows the liking scores for Alternative A.

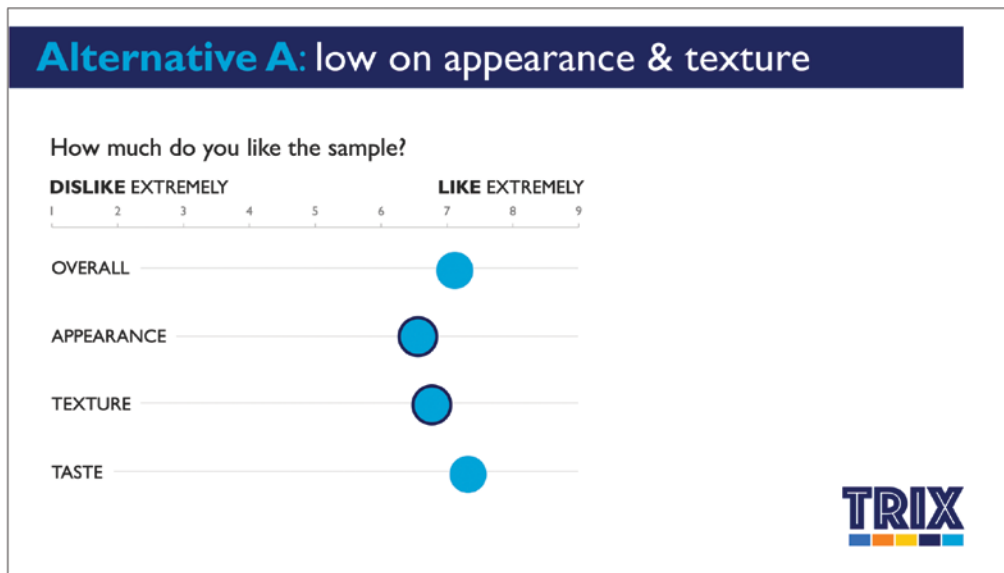


FIGURE 7.18 Make it clear how the views connect

With this step-wise approach, I make it clear to others how the various data points I am communicating all relate. I highlight through both my text and the contrasting formatting for the lower scores on appearance and texture (shown in Figure 7.18). I use this to transition into the subsequent level of detail from the taste test for Alternative A, which will allow me to share further insight into why these scores were low. The format of that data is different, so I'll use another graph there. I'll follow the same process of setting the stage and building it step by step to lead people through how to interpret the data and direct their attention to specific points of interest as I continue to progress through the story. You'll see how it all comes together later in the book.

Before we do that, there's an additional type of visual content that I'll integrate into my final presentation: images. Let's shift our attention there next.



illustrate with images

When may your topic or message be best served by an image? If you've ever presented from a stage, it's likely that you've contemplated and perhaps used pictures in your presentations. But what about in your normal day-to-day meetings with slides: when and how might you effectively use images there?

You've seen examples of what *not* to do. A stretched photo that has the sole purpose of filling empty space on the page, a stock image of hands shaking on a slide about partnerships, clip art or comic strips that are only tangentially related to the topic and distract or annoy rather than play any role of utility—these are instances to avoid. I have heard the directives that lead to these misuses: “We have some extra space on that slide; let's put something there,” or “You should spice up your deck with some pictures!” These statements illustrate both the wrong reasons to use images and the incorrect manner in which to use them.

Pictures used well are extremely powerful. They can help you explain concepts, increase understanding, maintain attention, reinforce content, improve memorability, and more. I'll mention that I'm using the words *image* and *picture* interchangeably. We'll explore a variety of specific image types soon, demonstrating through examples and sharing practical tips that will help you effectively integrate images of all types into your visual communications. Before we do that, let's get specific about why we might integrate pictures into our presentations in the first place.

Reasons to use images

There are a variety of reasons to use images in your visual communications. While not fully comprehensive, I've organized common ways to use pictures into four broad categories—to help explain and understand, aid memorability, set the tone, and improve the design. Let's discuss each of these in detail.

Images can help you explain and your audience understand

Put simply, incorporate a picture when it's helpful for others to see something. Use an image when looking at the thing will help your audience comprehend it better or the visual aid makes it easier for you to explain a subject or concept. For instance, imagine you work at a start-up and are putting together a pitch deck to help secure funding. You could include a sketched or computer-generated prototype of your flagship product for your venture capitalist audience, assisting your explanation and ensuring their understanding.

You can also use images to help frame your communication. We discussed setting up a navigation scheme in Chapter 5 in the context of plotting out the slides in a presentation (I shared an example using simple words and another that integrated photographs of my kids). To recap this approach, the image you'd use in this instance would encapsulate the primary sections or topics in your presentation. You'd introduce it near the beginning to set up what you will talk about and in what order. Then you'd revisit it as a transition point between sections to keep people oriented on where you've been and where you're going. Finally, you'd use it again near the end of the presentation to recap your main points.

Let's look at an example presentation from my work that employs this technique. I once put together a short session on the importance of decluttering data visualizations. I started with a story about how I used to get in trouble for not cleaning my room. It was part delay tactic that drove my childhood transgressions, but the resulting chaos made me realize that I had a difficult time concentrating in a disorganized environment. I used this anecdote as a

metaphor for how visual clutter in a graph translates into an inadequate viewer experience. Then I showed the following image of a messy desk to introduce the specific content I would cover.

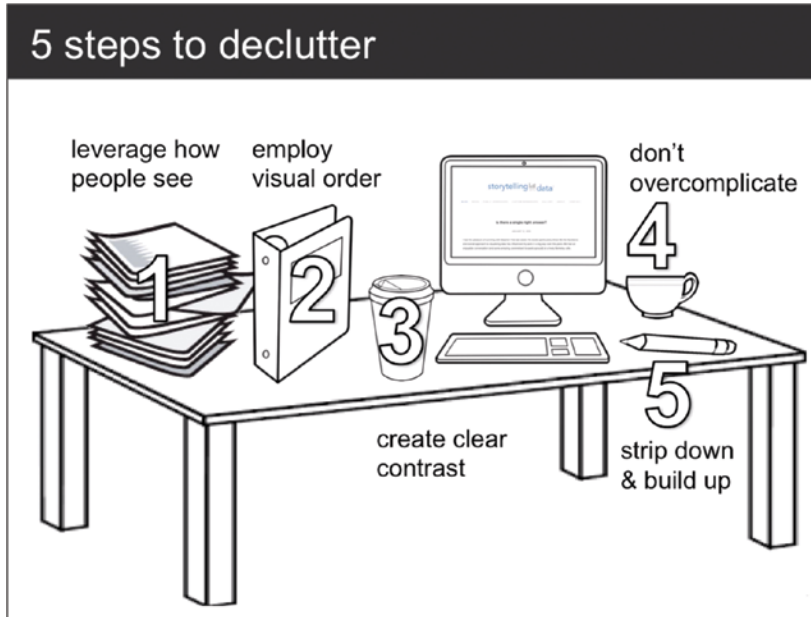


FIGURE 8.1 Navigation scheme with images: initial view

After talking through the visual navigation scheme shown in Figure 8.1, I transitioned to my first point using Figure 8.2.

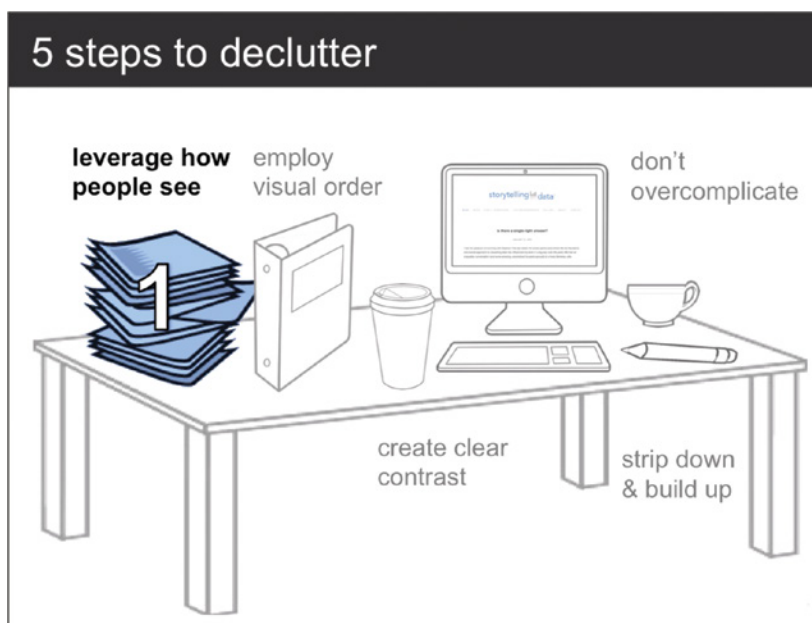


FIGURE 8.2 Navigation scheme with images: transitioning to first concept

I returned to versions of this image after each step, highlighting sparingly in a similar manner as a visual transition to close out one topic and introduce the next. (If you're interested in seeing the presentation, you can watch it at storytellingwithyou.com/declutter.)

This is another way to use images that will both assist you as the presenter and help tie things together in a manner that makes it easier for others to understand. As a bonus, the repetition of continually returning to the image and concepts makes it easier for others to remember what you've covered. Speaking of memorability, this is one potent power of pictures.

Images can aid memorability

An image used well improves your audience's ability to recall a concept or point. This is due to something known as the **Picture Superiority Effect**—people remember pictures better than words. This is thought to be due to the double encoding that happens with images (in both visual and verbal memory) versus

the single encoding in verbal memory with words. Numerous studies have found that recall is improved when an effective picture is combined with words compared to words alone.

The key word here is *effective*. You may have a great picture, but is it right for reinforcing your idea or message? Does it help others see something in your head? For the ideal picture-message combo, when your audience later recalls the picture, they are reminded of what you said when you showed it.

We incorporate a number of images into our *storytelling with data* workshop slides. In the context of directing attention, we often introduce the “Where are your eyes drawn?” test. As part of this exercise, we present various pictures and have participants shout out where their eyes are drawn first. This practice illustrates what happens to our visual attention in a number of different scenarios.

One set of images starts with a full screen of multicolored balloons. See Figure 8.3.



FIGURE 8.3 Where are your eyes drawn?

Colorful isn't a good goal when you would like your audience to look at one thing in particular. Contrast Figure 8.3 with the following image.



FIGURE 8.4 Sparing contrast focuses attention

I don't have to say the words, "Look at the blue balloon." When presented with Figure 8.4, you are already looking at it before I can even get them out of my mouth. Striking contrast—in particular, the sparing use of color—garners attention. If my audience later recalls either picture, they should remember the associated lesson. That is an example of an image used to illustrate *and* reinforce a point to aid memorability.

Images can set the tone

Carrying on with the topic of color, you may recall in Chapter 5 that we discussed how hue evokes feelings and can help you set the tone for a communication in the context of presentation design. Pictures do this as well—and have the potential to do so to a much greater degree.

I once began a workshop with the story of my daughter's birth. While this might seem like both a highly personal and unexpected experience to share in a business setting, I had concrete reasons for doing so. I was speaking to a group of physicians. Specifically, they were brain surgeons who spoke on behalf of a medical device company. My assignment was to convince them to approach things differently than they had done in the past. (How's that for a potentially intimidating audience and scenario?!) The setting was a hotel ball-room; I was in the front of the room presenting to about fifty surgeons.

In my story, I was hooked up to an electrocardiogram, watching the printed results unspool from a reel of paper beside me. I saw a peak, then a valley, a peak, then a valley—the data going up, then going down—and I was thinking to myself, that's an interesting graph. The doctor looked at the same piece of paper and proclaimed, "This is what active labor looks like!" Throughout this narrative, I had a blank slide at my back to focus the surgeons' attention on me. Then at the end, I put up two pictures of my beautiful daughter, Eloise: one in the Neonatal Intensive Care Unit and another roughly a year later.



FIGURE 8.5 Eloise, newborn and at one year

This before-and-after that demonstrated the marvels of modern medicine—something my physician attendees could certainly appreciate—was a dramatic

way to hint at the transformation I planned for the attendees that day. I was going to ask them to be vulnerable and look at things in a new way. By doing that myself at the start of the presentation, I got the undivided attention of every person in the room and began to build their trust. The story and the pictures helped them relate to me, establishing a rapport that set the foundation for the day.

I incorporate images of my children into my presentations in ways that some might find surprising. For me, it's natural. Because I learn a great deal from them, often the stories I tell within my presentations include them. I mention this not to encourage you to share personal photographs specifically. However, when you relate strongly to an image in some way, it is more likely that you'll be able to talk about the associated concepts and present that image in a way that will get others to connect with it, too.

For a less dramatic illustration of how pictures can help establish tone and align people, I'll draw on a client example. I once worked with an energy company, helping a group in operational risk with communications they were building for the leadership team. While reviewing a draft deck on the big screen in a working meeting, we flipped to a slide titled "Why do we purchase insurance?" There was a small picture at the top of the slide, followed by a lot of text. The words were organized into categories: to transfer the risk, to meet statutory requirements, and to meet contractual obligations. Each category contained several bullet points with more details.

I didn't know what the picture was showing because we were well outside the realm of my expertise. I started asking questions. It depicted a multi-million dollar machine breaking, highlighting the need for insurance. I could tell simply in the way that the group discussed it that the image was evoking the desired reaction. Unfortunately, the impact was being dampened by the current approach that incorporated a small image with many words. As part of the revamp, we made the image the focus of the slide, with the statement "Why we need insurance." The text in the original slide became talking points (preserved in the speaker notes section) for the communication.

Images can improve the design

There will be some instances where it might make sense to incorporate an image simply for the sake of aesthetics. Thinking back over my own use of images, I've done this more often with conference-style presentations than run-of-the-mill business presentations, though there may be opportunities in that setting, too.

If there is a powerful image that you make central to your communication, you can use it to set colors, fonts, and other design aspects to lend a cohesive and professional look and feel. In one of my favorite keynote presentations, I told a story about encountering my two-year-old son, Dorian, reading a book. He wasn't actually *reading* the words. He was retelling the tale aloud using the images to prompt his recall of the story he had heard many times before (another illustration of the power of pictures!). As part of my presentation, I shared that book and told an abbreviated version of the story to the audience.

The book is titled *Larry Gets Lost in Seattle*. It was written by John Skewes, who has authored an entire series based on Larry and his misadventures. Figure 8.6 shows a sample two-page spread.

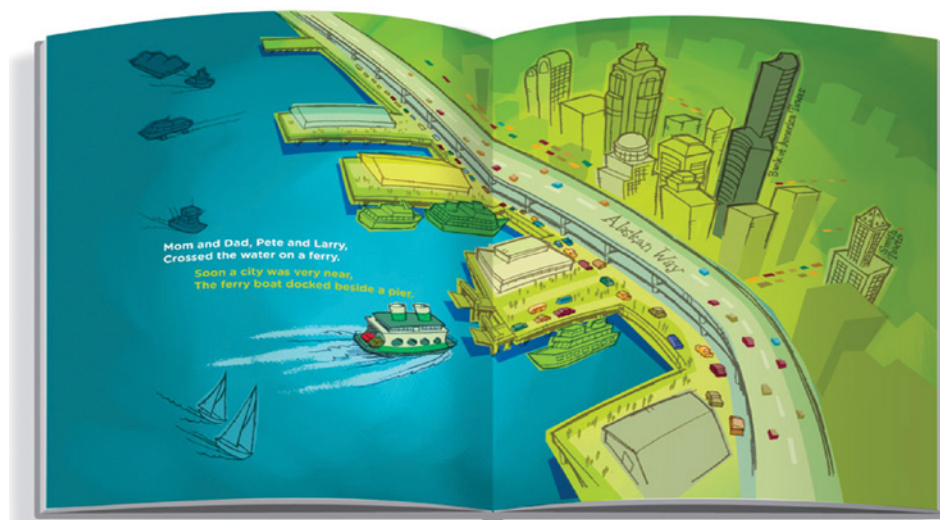


FIGURE 8.6 *Larry Gets Lost in Seattle* excerpt (© John Skewes)

Given the emphasis on this story, I folded some of the design aspects into my presentation. This included bold colors and some imagery from the *Larry Gets Lost* series (used with permission from the author). Figure 8.7 shows the title slide for my presentation (you may recognize it; a thumbnail was included in Chapter 6 as a conference presentation title slide).



FIGURE 8.7 My presentation title slide, inspired by *Larry Gets Lost in Seattle*

It is also sometimes useful to incorporate images simply to break up content or give people something to look at while you're speaking. While this seems counter to my earlier advice, I'd suggest not solely using images in this manner. Look for opportunities where one of the other purposes we've discussed can be met as well.

Using images in virtual presentations

With the shift toward more virtual meetings and presentations, I've found myself incorporating images in more ways. When setting context, describing a scenario, or telling a story in a live situation, I sometimes use a blank slide to ensure attention is on me. I tend not to do this when presenting virtually. It can be misinterpreted as a technical glitch or an invitation to turn attention to competing priorities (the email inbox is only a click away!). Instead, I've found myself including an image to give my audience something to look at while they listen to me. In one scenario about bank branch satisfaction, I used a picture of a bank branch while I was setting the context. On another occasion, the topic was back-to-school shopping, where I displayed an image from the given retailer while I spoke.

When using images in this way, they should directly tie to your topic and be something that others can look at without having to give it much thought—you still want their primary attention devoted to you and what you're saying. The picture is merely something that will entertain their eyes while their ears are on you. We'll discuss ways to hold your audience's attention through *how you speak* in a virtual environment in Chapter 10.

Given these powers of pictures, when designing a communication, step back and think about whether, where, and how your content could benefit from the inclusion of an image. As we've discussed already in the context of words and graphs—be intentional about your motivations for incorporating pictures into your presentations and specific about the purpose each serves. This will help you use images effectively.

You've seen a few examples of varied types of images already. Let's talk about three categories of pictures and some related tips and strategies.

Photographs, illustrations, and diagrams

I'm going to be broad with my definition of images and include visual content common to slide presentations that we've not yet covered in the chapters on words (Chapter 6) and graphs (Chapter 7). This includes photographs, illustrations, and diagrams. I'll discuss the use of each of these types of images, sharing related design considerations and additional illustrative examples.

I'll repeat a caveat that I expressed previously: I am not a trained designer. I have a good eye and have learned over time through trial and error, trusting my instincts, and learning from each instance. What follows are my pragmatic tips based on my experience using various forms of imagery in materials communicated in meetings and presentations.

Photographs

Probably the most common form of images encountered in business and other professional presentations is photographs.

I recall helping my husband with a slide deck when he was working at a wearables technology company. The founder was hyper-focused on great design when it came to their products, which was a feeling that needed to flow through to the visual communications used within the company, too. Given this context, in scenarios where I may otherwise have opted for words or graphs as content, we used striking imagery from photo archives that the company maintained. To discuss introducing an annual employee survey in one Quarterly Business Review—rather than a bulleted slide detailing the specifics (which the founder cared little about)—we used an image of employees at an all-hands meeting, with the simple words, “Let’s hear from the team.”

This brings me to my first tip for using photographs in presentations: commit to the image. Don't let it seem like an afterthought, placed in the corner of a slide where you had some unused space. Let it take center stage. This generally means making the photo take up the entire slide. Let's look at an example from the energy company client I mentioned earlier in the chapter.

Figure 8.8 shows a slide from a deck I was helping revamp (modified slightly to preserve confidentiality).

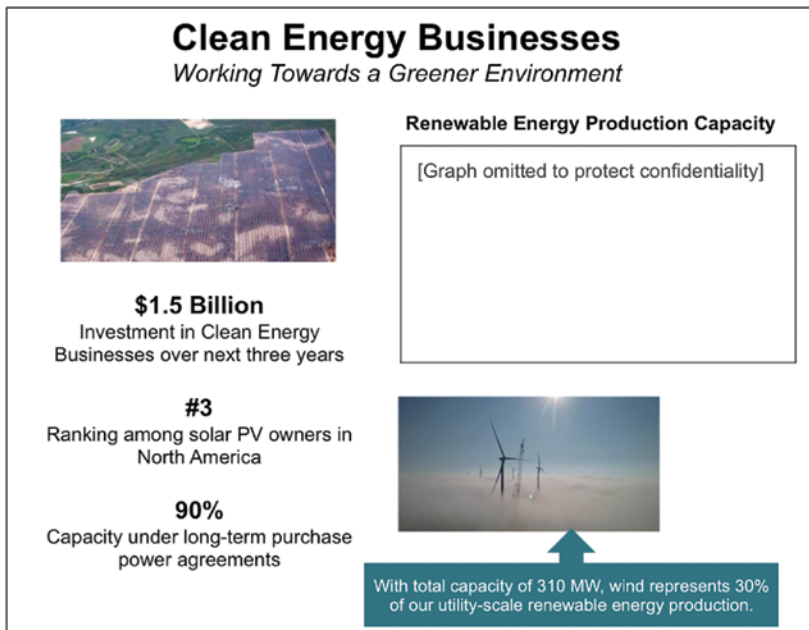


FIGURE 8.8 Original slide: suboptimal use of photographs

Note the callout near the bottom of the slide with the arrow pointing to the second photograph. Through discussion, I learned that this was one of the key points. Given this, I suggested that we convert the original slide into several, with each concentrating on a single primary message. The slide intended to do this for that final point is shown in Figure 8.9.



FIGURE 8.9 Commit to the image and pair with pithy text

In Figure 8.9, the photograph has been enlarged to cover the entire slide. When resizing photographs, take care not to stretch the image (changing the ratio between the original width and height will cause it to look distorted). Our eyes are quick to pick up on when this has been done, and it lends a feeling of unprofessionalism. Instead, you may have to crop one or more sides of the image to make the proportions work. Use high-resolution photographs that you can resize without looking fuzzy or grainy.

Where can I get photographs for my presentation?

There are a number of options for sourcing photographs. In some instances, it might make sense to take the photograph yourself, which is what I do when possible. This puts you in full control to make the picture exactly what you require without any concern over potential copyright issues.

Taking a photo to suit your situation won't always be possible. When it isn't, you may opt for stock photography. There are a variety of free and paid options. Here are a few that I have used:

- **iStock** by Getty Images ([istockphoto.com](https://www.istockphoto.com)) has a good library of paid photos and illustrations, with various pricing plans and subscriptions. Other popular pay-for-photo sites include **Shutterstock** ([shutterstock.com](https://www.shutterstock.com)), **Getty Images** ([gettyimages.com](https://www.gettyimages.com)), and **Adobe Stock** (stock.adobe.com).
- **Flickr Creative Commons** ([flickr.com/photos/creativecommons/](https://www.flickr.com/photos/creativecommons/)) offers various types of licenses (many of which only call for simple attribution).
- **Free Images** ([freeimages.com](https://www.freeimages.com)), **pixabay** ([pixabay.com](https://www.pixabay.com)), and **Unsplash** (unsplash.com) have free images for personal and commercial use.

These are a few of the many sites where you can search and access or purchase photographs. Always read the fine print so you are aware of any licensing or attribution requirements.

When it comes to orienting photographs and other imagery on your slides, one design tenet to be familiar with is the **Rule of Thirds**. This is a guideline that lends a well-composed feeling to your images (and can be more generally applied to slide design as well). Imagine dividing your image into thirds, both across length and height, leaving you with a grid of nine equal areas. The Rule of Thirds suggests placing the key subjects or graphic elements along the lines that divide the image into thirds or at the intersections of those lines. The general idea is that it gives the onlooker's eyes somewhere to move while viewing your photograph, image, or slide. This is in contrast to positioning key elements in the center.

Let's look at a photograph I've used before—one I took of my son, Dorian. I mentioned the scenario earlier in the chapter about two-year-old Dorian telling himself the story of *Larry Gets Lost in Seattle*. See Figure 8.10 for two versions of the photo that illustrates this.

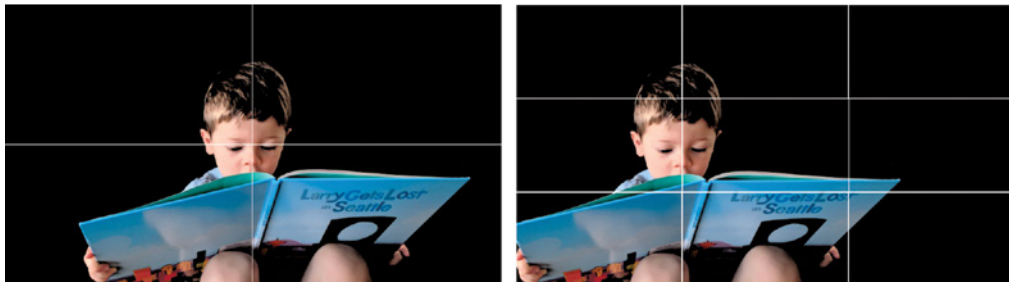


FIGURE 8.10 Center focus compared to Rule of Thirds

Compare the left and right images in Figure 8.10. Do they feel different to you? Following the Rule of Thirds, we should favor the second version of the image, where Dorian is positioned at the left line in the 9-rectangle grid, rather than centered in the 4-rectangle grid. As a bonus, when it comes to using photographs in slides where we also want to overlay text, the latter version provides a bigger block of space in the upper right to do so.

I'll impart a final piece of advice on the topic of photographs, something I alluded to at the onset of this chapter. When integrating them into your presentation, avoid anything that is trite, unimaginative, or overused. Resist any urge to use pictures of money when you talk about sales, a bullseye for communicating targets, or a photo of the earth to discuss your global presence. These have been done before (many times!) and are not likely to add value or be memorable.

Instead, determine how you want people to feel and what you want them to understand or remember at given points during your presentation. Could a photograph help you accomplish these goals? This reflection alone will help you use photography purposefully.

Apply this sound advice to the next type of image we'll talk about, too: illustrations.

Illustrations

I use *illustration* to describe any type of visual content that is drawn. Drawn images will typically feel less polished than a photograph. I highlight this not as a negative quality but as an aspect that helps inform when and why you might opt to use an illustration in a presentation instead of a photograph. As we've been doing with each type of content we consider (words, graphs, photographs), when determining whether to include illustrations, start by being clear on your reason for doing so.

Illustrated images can take a variety of forms—refined or rough, realistic or abstract. Check out the illustrations in Figure 8.11.



FIGURE 8.11 Three drawings of a bird

What are a few adjectives you would use to describe each of the three birds in Figure 8.11?

Starting at the left, with the more realistic version of the heron, my list includes: stately, attentive, and statuesque. The middle bird strikes me as quick, bare, and bold. Finally, for the bird on the right, I would use descriptors like silly, lighthearted, and amusing.

Your lists of adjectives will look different than mine, and that's okay. The point is that different styles of illustrations (even when they are picturing basically the same thing) convey varying tones and evoke distinct sets of feelings. Understanding this will better equip you to choose an illustration style that will reinforce the general vibe you'd like to set.

I draw on paper—and, increasingly, an iPad

When a simple illustration will suit, I often tackle this myself and sketch it. I'm definitely not an artist, but I enjoy drawing. When I spend a little time, I can do it reasonably well. I'm most comfortable drawing on paper. To translate paper drawings to the electronic world, I'll either scan or take a picture of the image and then recolor or make other minor edits

in PowerPoint so it will fully meet my needs. This definitely isn't the most technologically advanced technique, but it generally works for me!

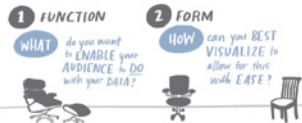
Inspired by the enthusiasm expressed by some of my teammates who draw on their iPads (and their beautiful work), I've slowly started building my skills and experimenting there, too. I've tried a few different apps; my favorite is Procreate. I find it intuitive, and it has enough options to meet my objectives without feeling overwhelming. The herons in Figure 8.11 were drawn on my iPad using Procreate.

One place I used a number of illustrations was in my second book, *storytelling with data: let's practice!* While not a presentation per se, this is an example of the thought process behind using illustrations in visual communication. The book isn't one that's meant to simply be read; it is intended to be an immersive experience—I want people to roll up their sleeves and do some work. I knew early on when I was planning the content that I would want it to be illustrated for a number of reasons. First, I liked the idea of a large, potentially intimidating book contrasted with light and fun illustrations. My hope was that the images would make the book feel more accessible, too.

The hand-drawn look was intentional to visually reinforce the idea that approaching things in a less formal way is okay and invite readers to draw. The primary illustrated content includes sticky notes with hand-written text and chapter recaps to summarize key lessons in a visual manner. Figure 8.12 shows an example of the latter.

THINK like a DESIGNER

FORM follows FUNCTION



AFFORDANCES

ASPECTS of the DESIGN that make it OBVIOUS HOW to USE



ACCESSIBILITY

DESIGN that is USABLE by PEOPLE of WIDELY VARYING TECHNICAL SKILLS

- 1 Make it LEGIBLE
- 2 Keep it CLEAN
- 3 Use PLAIN LANGUAGE
- 4 Remove UNNECESSARY COMPLEXITY



AESTHETICS

More VISUALLY APPEALING DESIGNS are PERCEIVED as EASIER to USE and are MORE READILY ACCEPTED

- Is it necessary to "make it pretty?" ...YES!
- 1 Be smart with color
 - 2 Pay attention to alignment
 - 3 Leverage white space



ACCEPTANCE

For your DESIGN to be EFFECTIVE, it must be ACCEPTED by the INTENDED AUDIENCE

- What if they resist change?
- 1 Articulate the benefits
 - 2 Show the side-by-side
 - 3 Provide multiple options or rock around
 - 4 Get a vocal audience member on board



FIGURE 8.12 Chapter recap illustration from *storytelling with data: let's practice!*

Illustrated content can make sense in cases when you simply can't use a photograph. I'll bring to mind a previous example: communicating about a product that hasn't been created yet. A drawing helps people see and ensure they are envisioning the same thing rather than vastly different ideas. As another benefit of illustrations, if you are the one drawing or commissioning the work, you can specify details so that the resulting illustration is exactly what you want. It doesn't have to exist in reality in the way that's required with a photo.

Like photography, if you aren't skilled yourself, getting good illustrations will likely mean spending some money. A number of the stock photography sites listed earlier in this chapter have searchable illustrations as well. There may also be situations where it makes sense to hire a professional (that's what I did for this book and *storytelling with data: let's practice!*, which were illustrated by the talented Catherine Madden).

On the topic of illustrations, I recommend avoiding clip art (the pre-made illustrations that are available in your slide application) and comics. It's for the same reasons that I suggest avoiding trite photography—it does little good and can sometimes harm. There are probably reasonable exceptions on the comic front but proceed cautiously. They can undermine your credibility and the perceived professionalism and seriousness of what you are presenting.

Diagrams

Whereas photographs and illustrations evoke feelings and help introduce or reinforce ideas, when there's a process, concept, or relationship between elements that is helpful to see, opt for a diagram. Diagrams can take a variety of shapes and forms. Rather than review specific types of diagrams in this section, I'll outline some general tips.

To start, as I did with photographs and illustrations, I encourage you to think about what it is you want to communicate in your diagram. A great tool to assist your thought process is a blank piece of paper. This will allow you to test different shapes quickly to find a general form that works. Then determine whether any predefined templates exist in your slideware to use as a starting point or if you need to build your diagram from scratch.

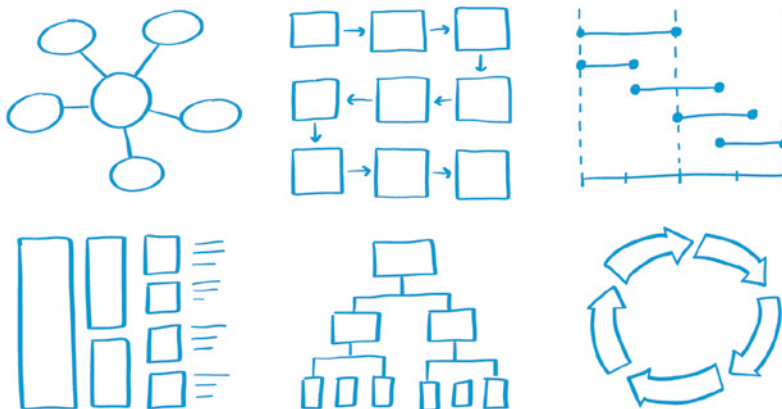


FIGURE 8.13 Diagram sketches

Another benefit of designing first on paper is that it makes it more difficult for clutter to work its way into your design. The same lessons that we covered in Chapters 6 and 7 for eliminating clutter and using sparing contrast to direct attention in text and graphs apply to diagrams as well. Some common clutter culprits to watch out for in diagrams are distracting borders or shapes and unnecessary or suboptimal uses of color.

Borders and connecting shapes like lines and arrows can often be pushed to the background. As we experienced when we de-emphasized elements of our graphs in Chapter 7, this makes it easier to create contrast to focus attention in what remains. If there is a node or section where you'd like others to look, make it visually distinct from the rest. For example, use color only there.

You can also use contrast in a live setting to help you talk through your diagram. In the same way we built graphs piece by piece in Chapter 7, it sometimes makes sense to reveal diagrams gradually as well. This ensures people don't jump ahead. Or, if it's helpful to see the shape of the overall diagram, use sparing color or other emphasis to progress through nodes or sections. This both acts as a guide to you as you're speaking as well as visual anchoring for your audience so they know exactly where to look in the diagram at any given time.

For example, Figure 8.14 shows two versions of the same simple diagram. The left-hand side has heavy borders and connecting arrows plus quite a lot of color. Compare this to the version on the right. Borders and even some background shading were eliminated. The arrows and remaining background shading were changed to gray—still present to set apart the discrete steps and help us understand the flow but not competing for attention. I assumed on the right that I'm discussing the diagram live and emphasizing a single node at a time as I progress through it, with current emphasis on the Sign In step that takes place on the Day of Event. Notice how much more flexibility exists for creating contrast and directing attention in the version on the right.

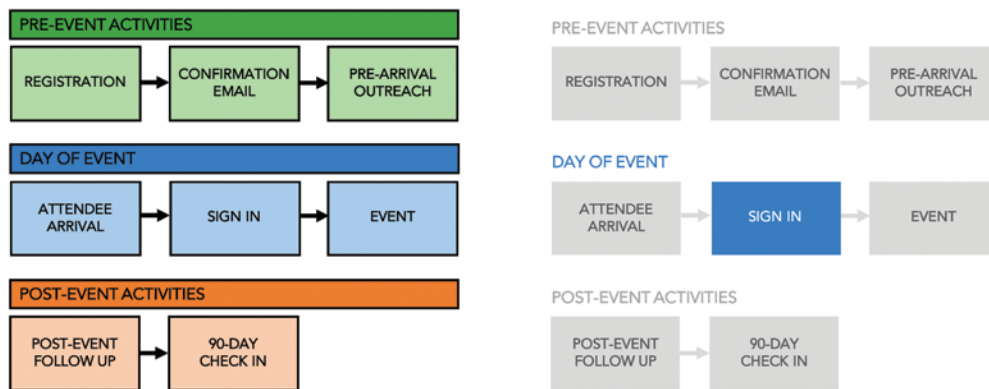


FIGURE 8.14 Two versions of the same diagram

A diagram used well will make something easier to understand, not feel more complicated. When creating a diagram, there's a delicate balance between choosing the right amount of information to show and draw attention to. This may mean that some of the specifics in your diagram become talking points and that you display a stripped down or simplified version in your presentation.

Expanding on this idea, one approach—which is particularly useful when there is important information to communicate at the high level and the specifics are also important—can be to show a simplified version of the entire diagram. Use this to set the context of the full picture for your audience. Then highlight a specific node or section and go into detail about that on subsequent slides. I might use the diagram on the right-hand side of Figure 8.14 to introduce the sign-in activity, then go to a slide or series of slides that explains what that entails.

Following this, you can then reorient people with the same simplified version of the high-level diagram before moving on to the detail in another section. This idea is similar to the navigation scheme we've looked at several times already for helping orient others in your presentation, where the diagram itself becomes your navigation scheme.

What about maps?

Is a map a picture, a data visualization, or a diagram? Maps can take on any of these roles, depending on how you use them, and sometimes serve multiple purposes simultaneously. Maps work well when there's something about the geospatial aspect that is important for people to know—for instance, if it's a lesser known geographical area and the specifics are critical. Another instance is when you are communicating data and there is a clear regional concentration (high or low) that would be otherwise difficult to ascertain.

For those who build—or would like to build—maps, a fantastic resource is the book *Cartography* by Kenneth Field (Esri, 2018). Listen to me chat with Kenneth in Episode 41 of the *storytelling with data* podcast (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

There are a number of tips and strategies that have come up over the course of this book in multiple places. I'll list a few of them: using a navigation scheme to orient yourself and your audience, decluttering and focusing attention, always being intentional about *why* you're using the content you're including. Many of the design aspects I've talked about specific to one area or type of content apply to others, too. I encourage you to think holistically about the content you create and how you can make it work best for you and for your audience.

Diagrams assist your explanation and increase others' understanding. Illustrations set and reinforce tone. Photographs help people relate to you and your topic. Pictures in general help your audience remember what you said. All of these things are pretty powerful. After our review, I hope you are thinking differently about when and how you'll use images in your presentations.

This wraps up the *create* section of the book. You'll recall that we began in Chapter 5 by bringing the low-tech plan that we created in the first section into our slideware, setting the design and structure of our presentation. Then we explored concepts and saw many examples of how to develop content: say it with words, show data in graphs, and illustrate with images.

If you're working on a project as you read and have been developing your content slides as we've progressed through the past few chapters, now is an excellent time to take a step back and look again at how it all fits together. This is often a good point at which to share your work with others and solicit feedback as well. There will be opportunities to continue to refine your materials now with this comprehensive view.

But don't spend *all* of your remaining time here. The materials you present are only one part of the equation. *You* are the other. Your role is a critically important one, which we'll delve into in the final section of the book.

Before we do that, let's return to the case study and determine whether and how to incorporate images into the presentation content.

Illustrate with images: TRIX case study

Could the materials I'm preparing for my client team at Nosh benefit from the inclusion of any images? To help make this determination, let's revisit the structure that we set in Chapter 6 and consider where there might be opportunities. You will recall that we've looked at this previously in slide sorter view. For easy reading, I'll list out the draft slide titles of my planned storyline:

- TRIX trail mix: most popular product
- Ah nuts! Macadamia price increase
- Decision: increase price or reduce cost?
- We tested packaging

- Taste test: assessed three mixes
- Participants prefer the original mix
- Apricots made Alternative A too soft
- Alternative B: people don't like hazelnuts
- Alternative B: people love coconut
- Decisions to weigh

In reading through this list, I don't see any obvious ways to incorporate photographs of my kids or my amateur sketches (kidding!); let's contemplate what other imagery might prove useful.

In Chapter 5, I showed a slide illustrating the winding path, shown again in Figure 8.15.

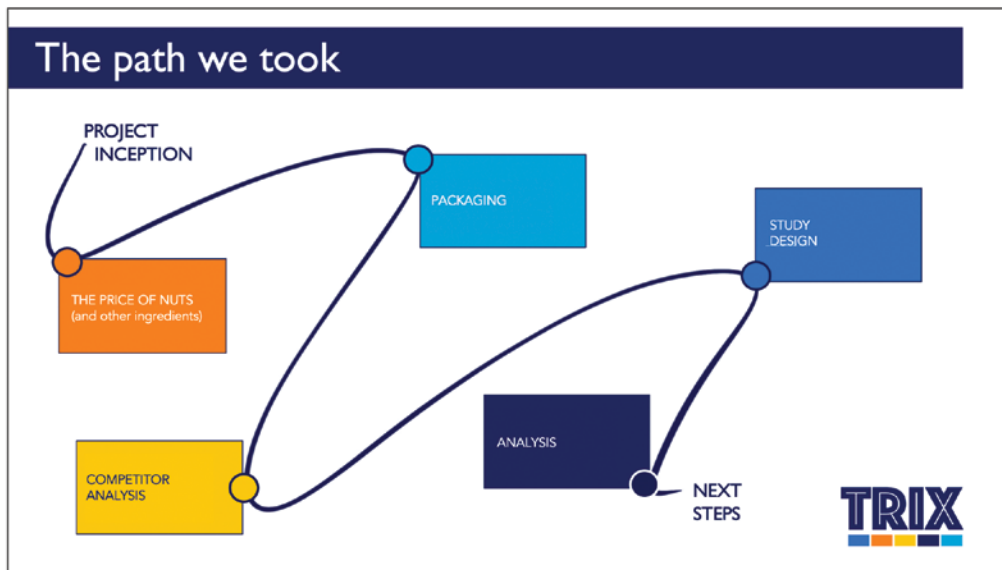


FIGURE 8.15 A diagram to show the winding path

This diagram will help me explain the general path we took to come up with our recommendations (and will also act as a navigation scheme for the infor-

mation that I'll include as supplementary material in the appendix of my slide deck). I sketched it on paper first and am happy I did so. If I'd jumped straight into templated diagrams in my tool, it would have been easy to end up with a linear flow. By starting with paper, it encouraged me to think about what I wanted to show my audience: that it *wasn't* a straight path, and we took a number of twists and turns to get to the final step. Once I had the concept on paper, I made my own shapes in PowerPoint (I drew the curved line, and the rest are simple rectangles that I've formatted as desired).

As we've discussed, this is a high-stakes presentation about an important component of the client group's business. When it comes to incorporating other types of pictures, I have to be discerning in my use of images if I do include them.

As part of our testing, we compared the current packaging to a new version that incorporates a view window so consumers can see the trail mix. This seems like an obvious place to include photographs of the two types of packages. Doing so will visually reinforce the topic and ensure everyone is picturing the same thing when I refer to the view window that was preferred.



FIGURE 8.16 Photo of product packaging tested

We'll also be discussing trail mixes of various compositions. We can certainly do this verbally and describe what is in each or even list the ingredients on a slide. It could also work to show them directly so that people see them, providing everyone a visual cue.

This is an instance where I require specific photographs: close-ups of each of the three trail mixes tested where we clearly see the composition of each (and the differences in composition between the three). No stock photos are going to help with this! I am lucky to have a teammate, Alex, who has a keen eye for detail and some time to help me with this. I ask Alex to stage photos of the three mixes. See Figure 8.17.



FIGURE 8.17 Photos of the three trail mixes tested

These trail mix images look pretty fantastic! Alex is not a photographer, and she didn't use any fancy tools, but she *did* incorporate her ingenuity. Each trail mix was put in a small clear glass prep bowl to contain it and lend a circular shape. She placed the bowls on a white window sill, both for the neutral background and natural light. Then Alex photographed them (with her iPhone 8 camera), trying different angles and playing with the arrangement of the ingredients in the bowls. Because there was clear contrast between the nuts, the glass bowl, and the white window sill, she didn't do much after that to modify the images. Alex used PowerPoint's built-in functionality to remove the background (those who don't have PowerPoint might use [remove.bg](#), a free online tool). In all, the process from arranging trail mix ingredients in a

bowl to what you see in Figure 8.17 took about 30 minutes—and yielded custom and professional-looking photos to incorporate into my deck.

I plan to introduce the trail mix images one by one on the same slide so that my audience sees the ingredients as I describe the composition of each. In this manner, the photograph will help me both remember and reinforce for others the makeup of each mix. After that, I think there may be opportunities to integrate the images again on some of the data slides as I review with the Nosh team the results of our taste test. This will help keep everyone straight about the different mixes and relative preferences across the various dimensions for each.

I've started some solid content for my presentation deck. I'll finish fleshing it out and get feedback from my team. I also plan to share it with some friendly folks in my client group to get confirmation that this will be an effective approach for the broader audience. You'll get an opportunity to see the entire presentation a little later in the book.

As the date for my meeting with the client team draws near, I need to make sure I'm spending time developing not just my content but myself, too. Next, let's turn our attention to what I can do—and what *you* can do—to prepare to deliver a stellar presentation.

